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(54) **SYSTEM AND METHOD FOR PROVIDING
ENHANCED RECOMMENDATIONS BASED
ON THIRD-PARTY OPINIONS**

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(57)

ABSTRACT

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(63) Continuation of application No. 18/068,981, filed on
Dec. 20, 2022, now Pat. No. 12,353,488, which is a
continuation of application No. 16/746,685, filed on
Jan. 17, 2020, now Pat. No. 11,537,673.

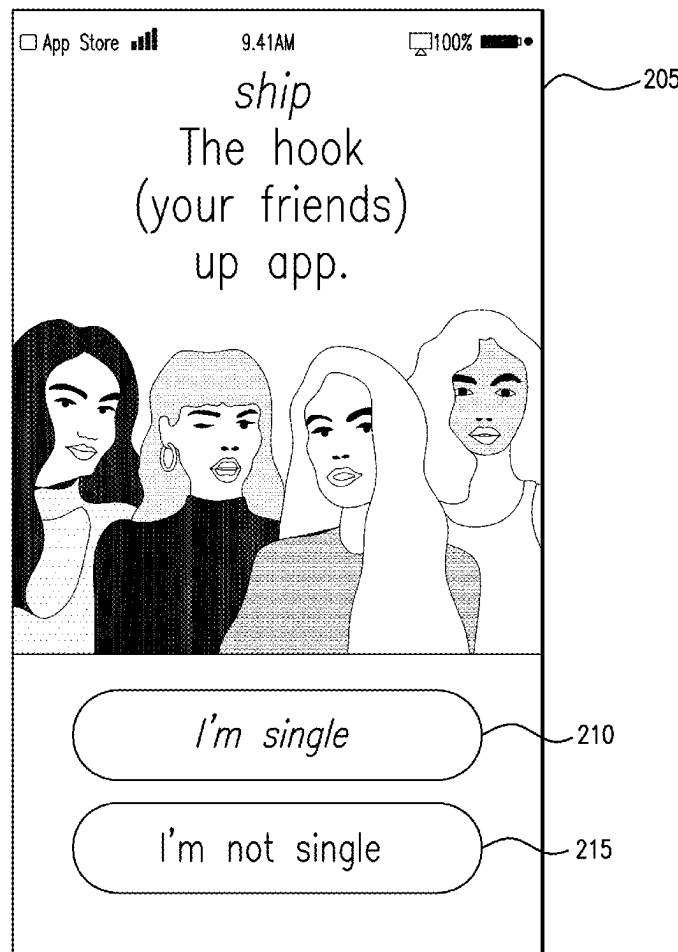
An apparatus includes an interface and a processor. The interface sends and receives data over a network. The processor uses the interface to transmit a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles corresponds to recommendations of users for a second user. The processor also uses the interface to receive a selection from the first user of a first profile of the first series of profiles. In response to receiving the selection from the first user of the first profile of the first series of profiles, the processor determines, based at least in part on the selection from the first user of the first profile, a second series of profiles. The processor additionally uses the interface to transmit the second series of profiles to the second user.

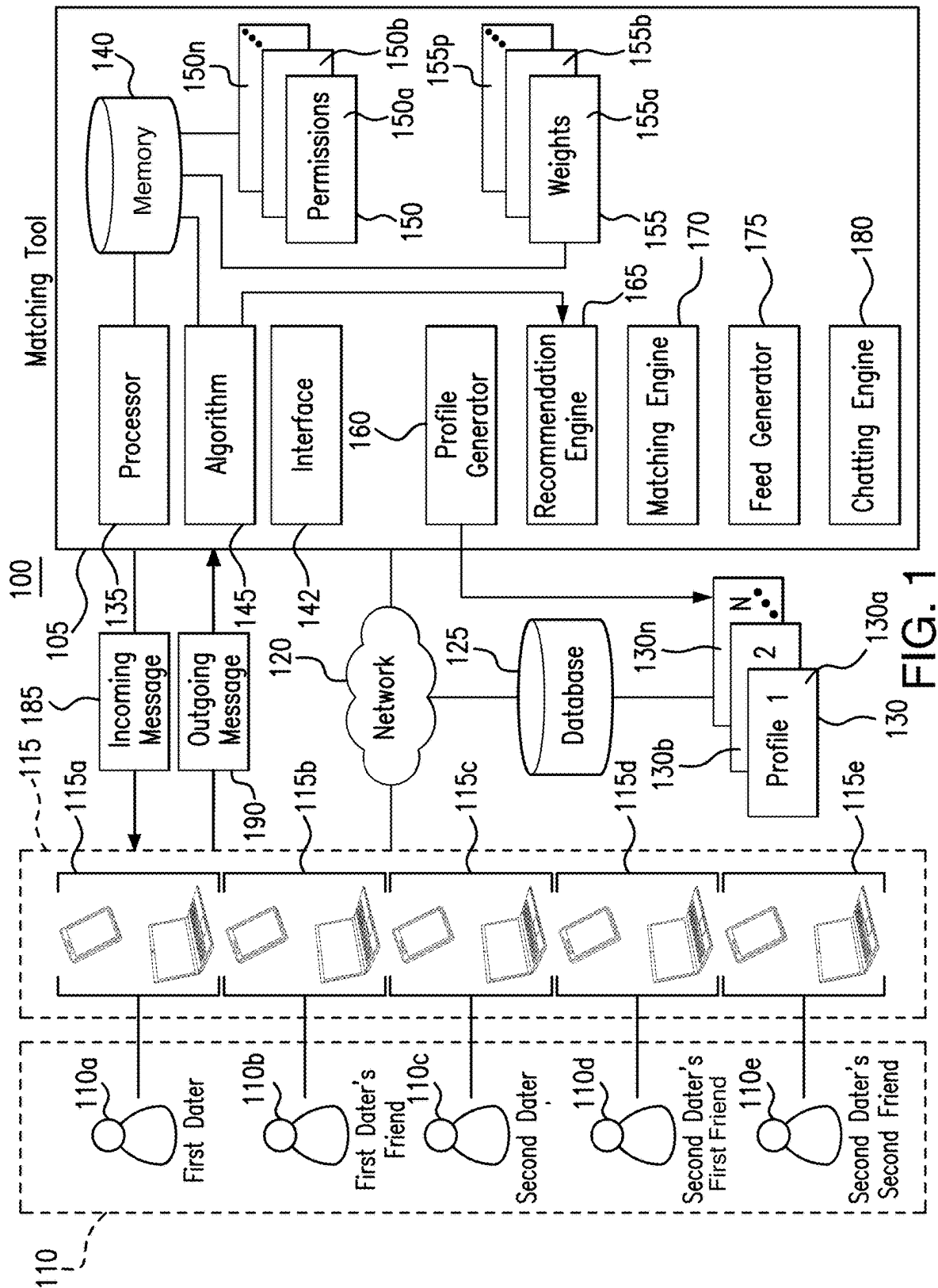
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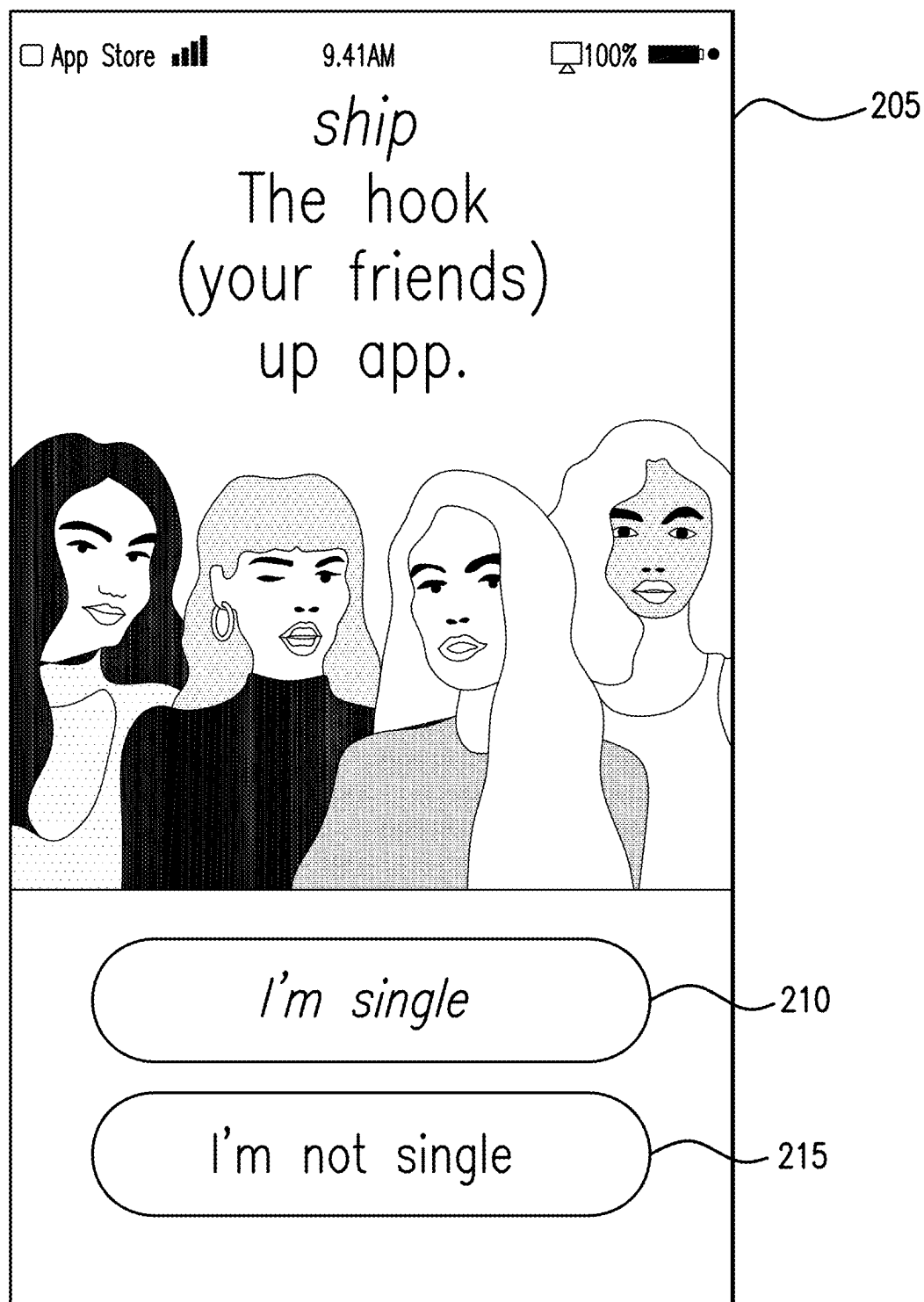


FIG. 2A

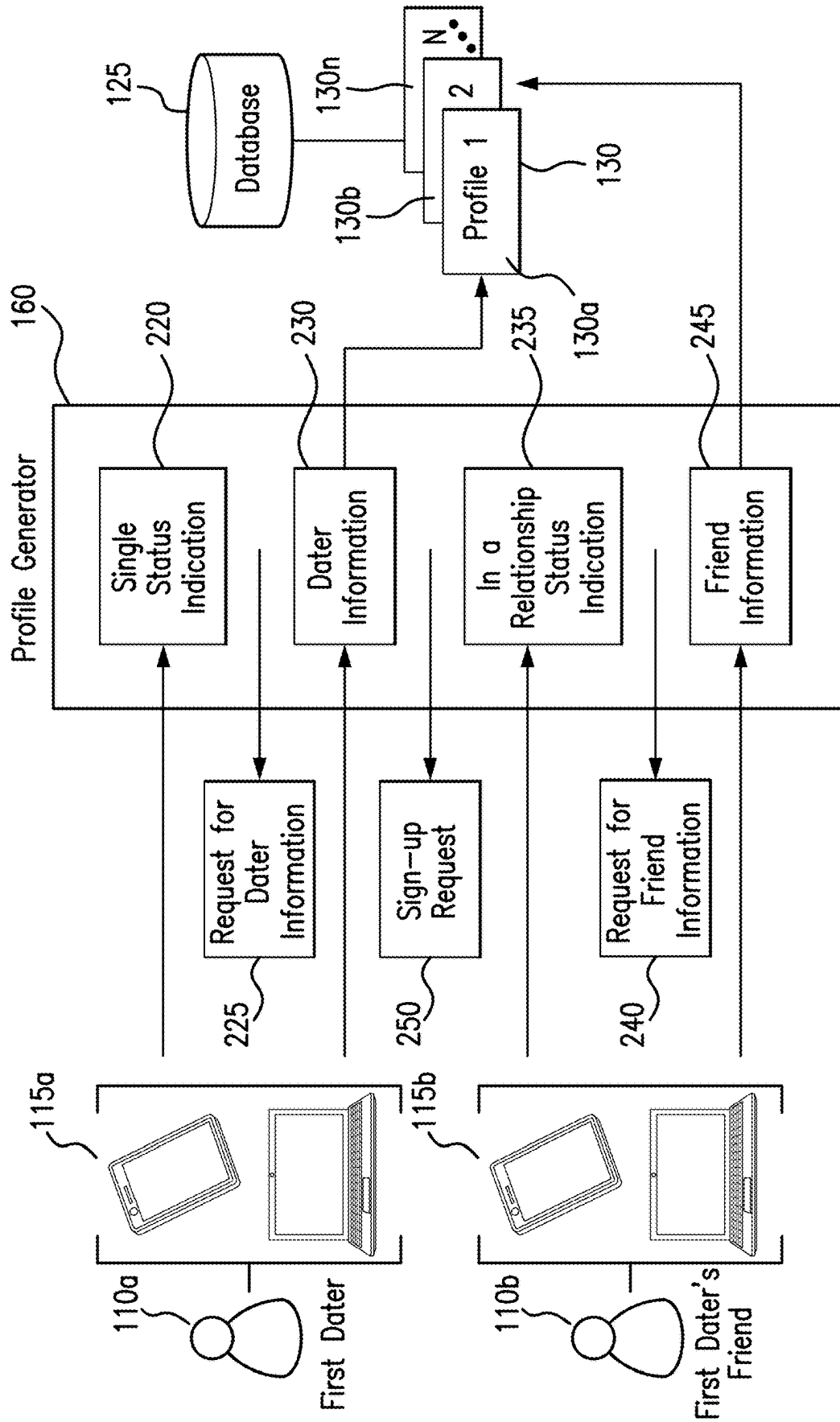


FIG. 2B

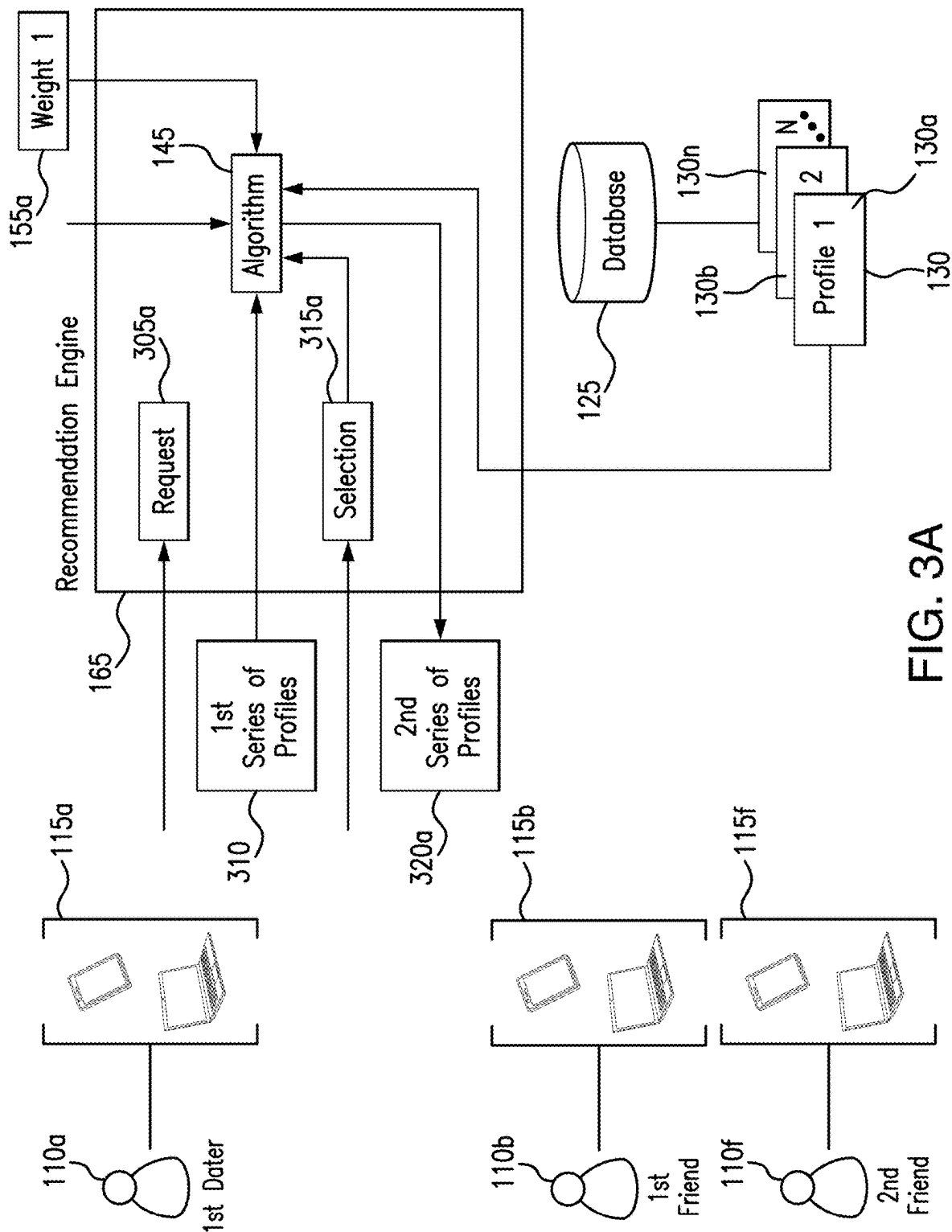


FIG. 3A

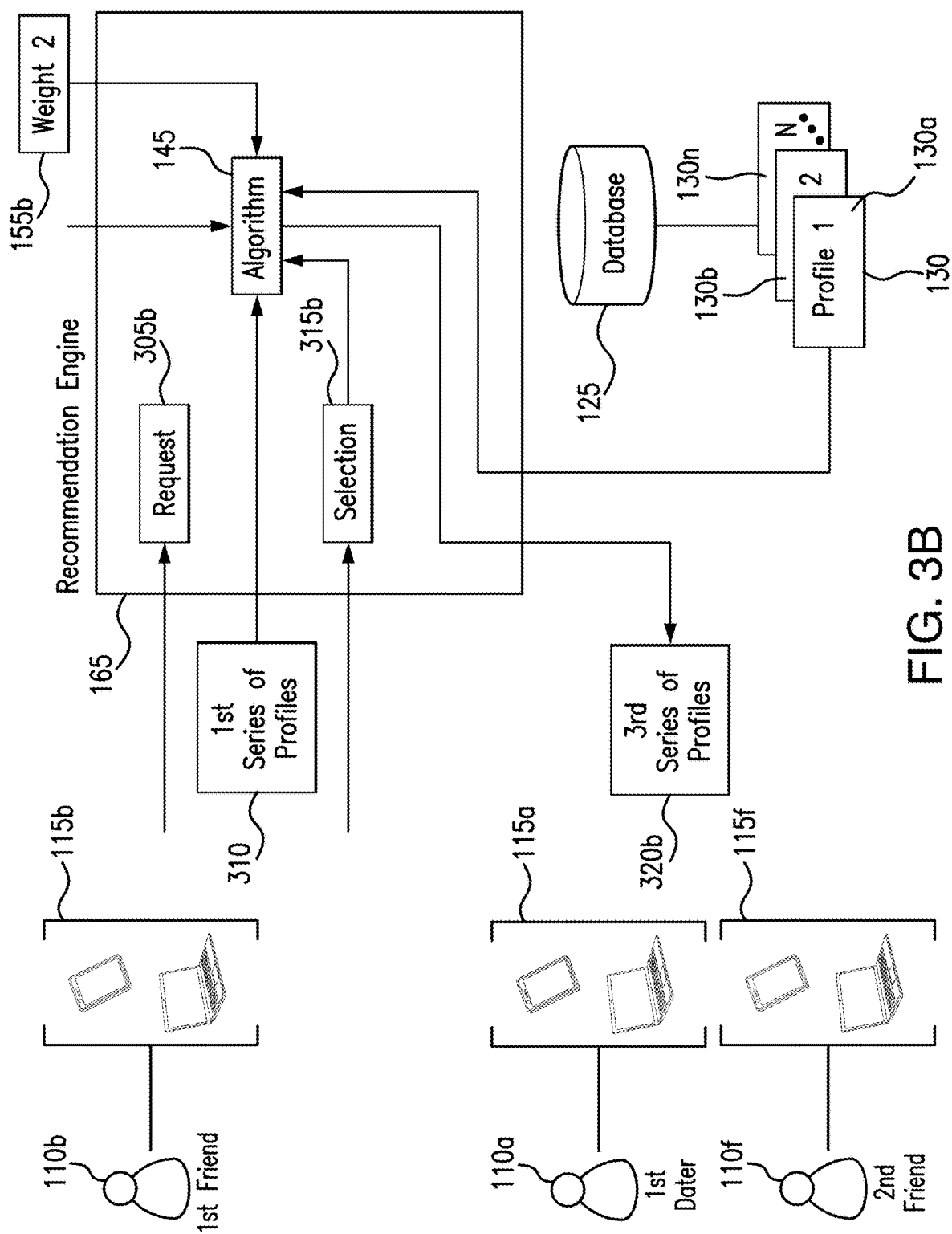


FIG. 3B

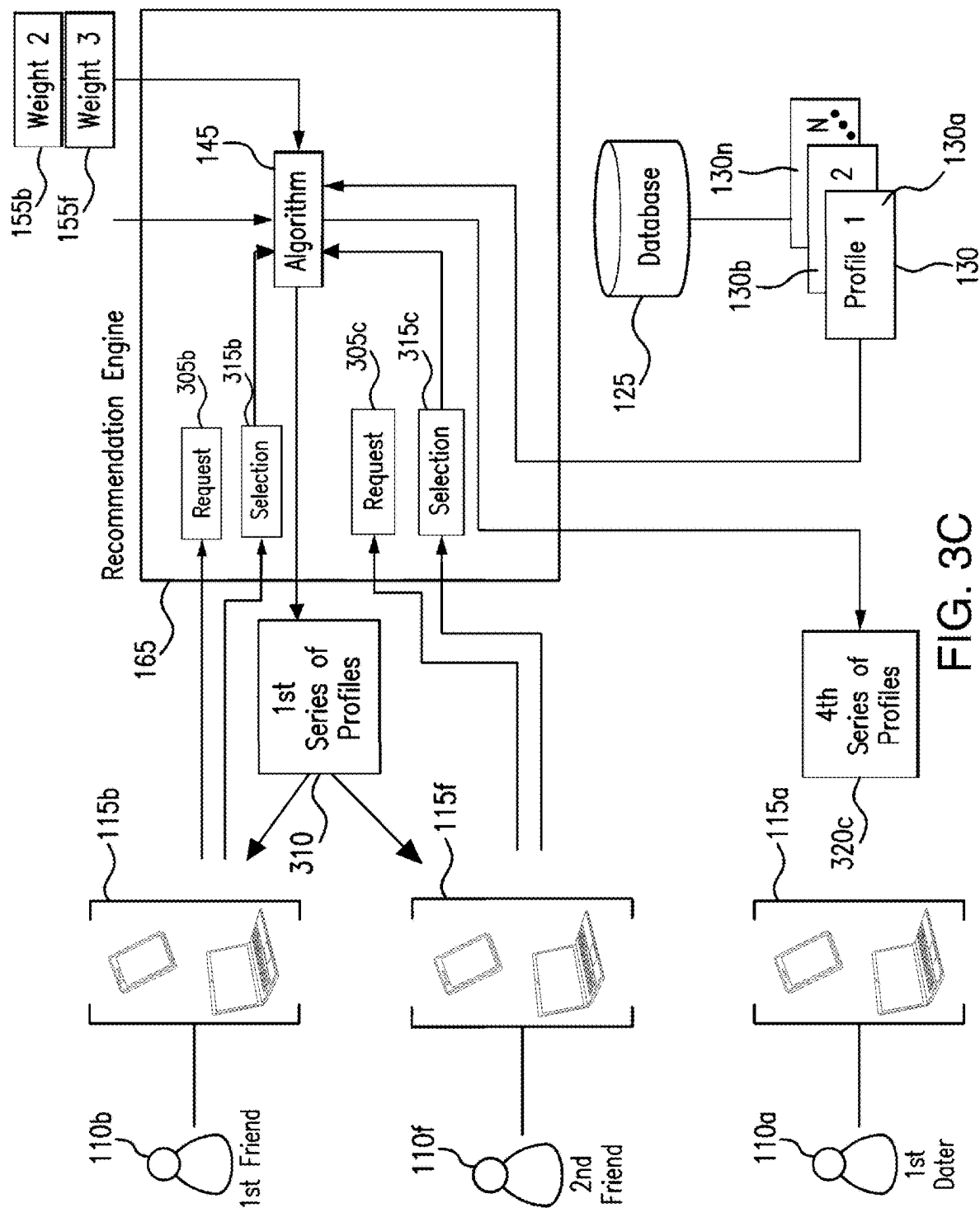


FIG. 3C

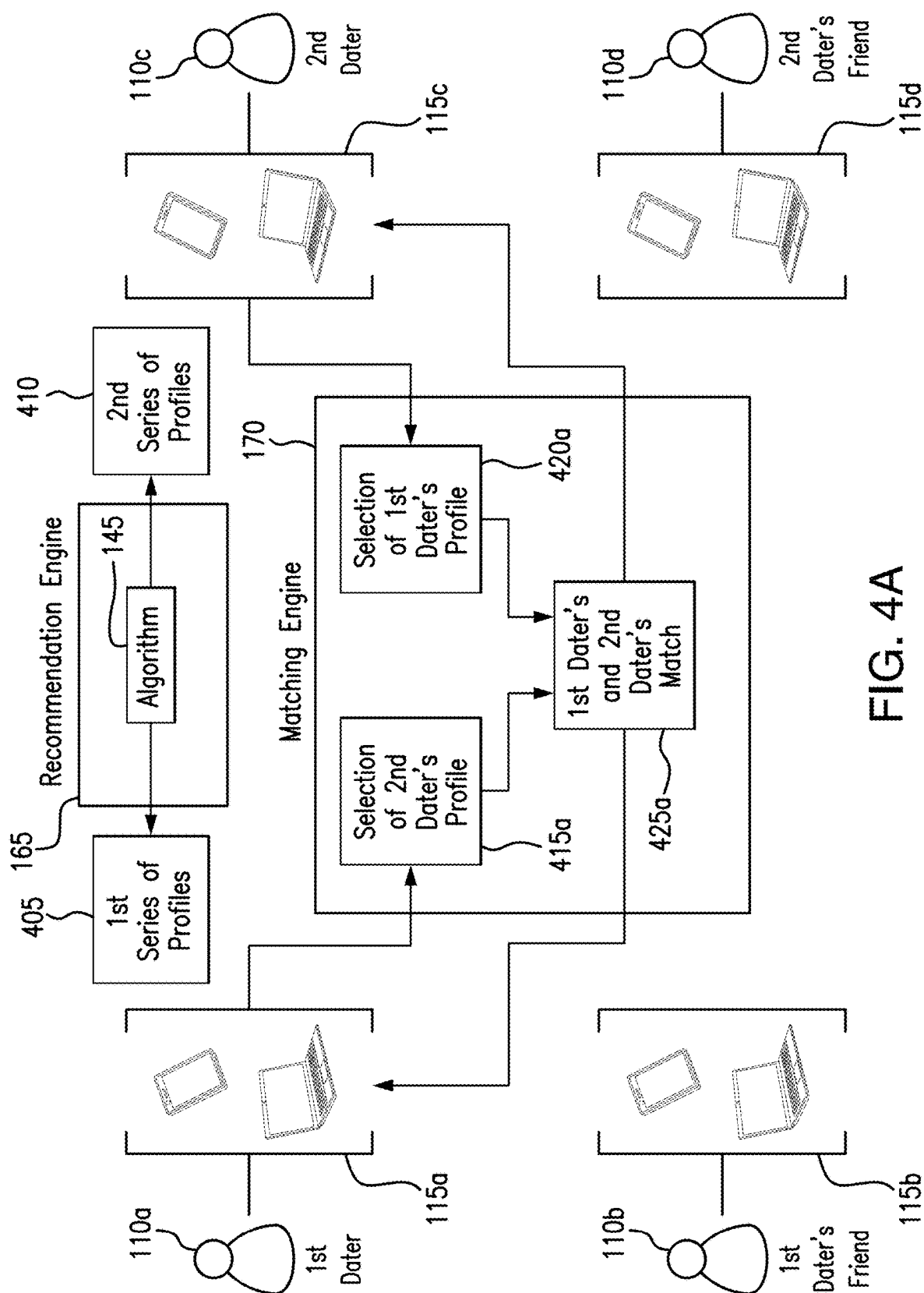
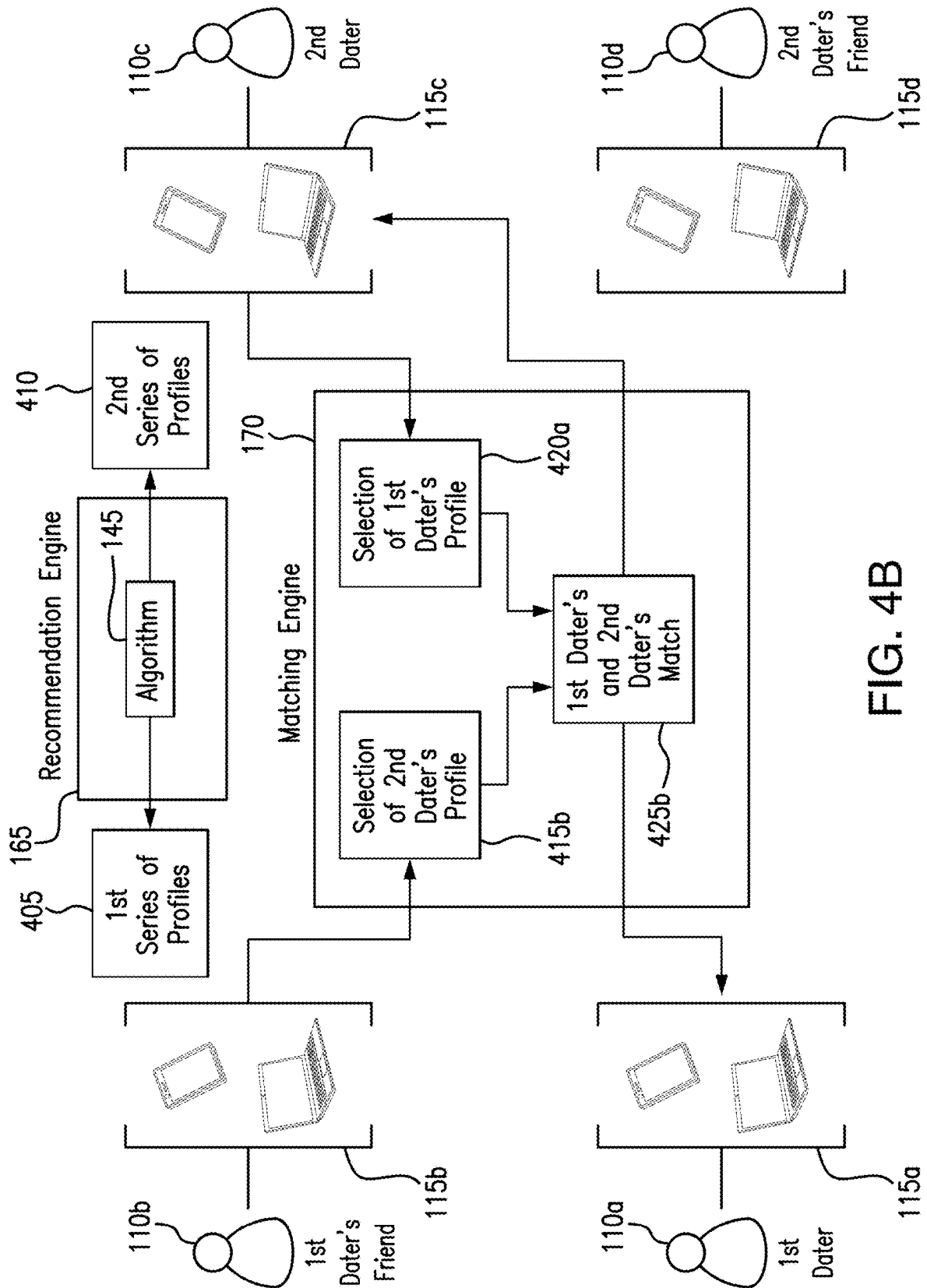
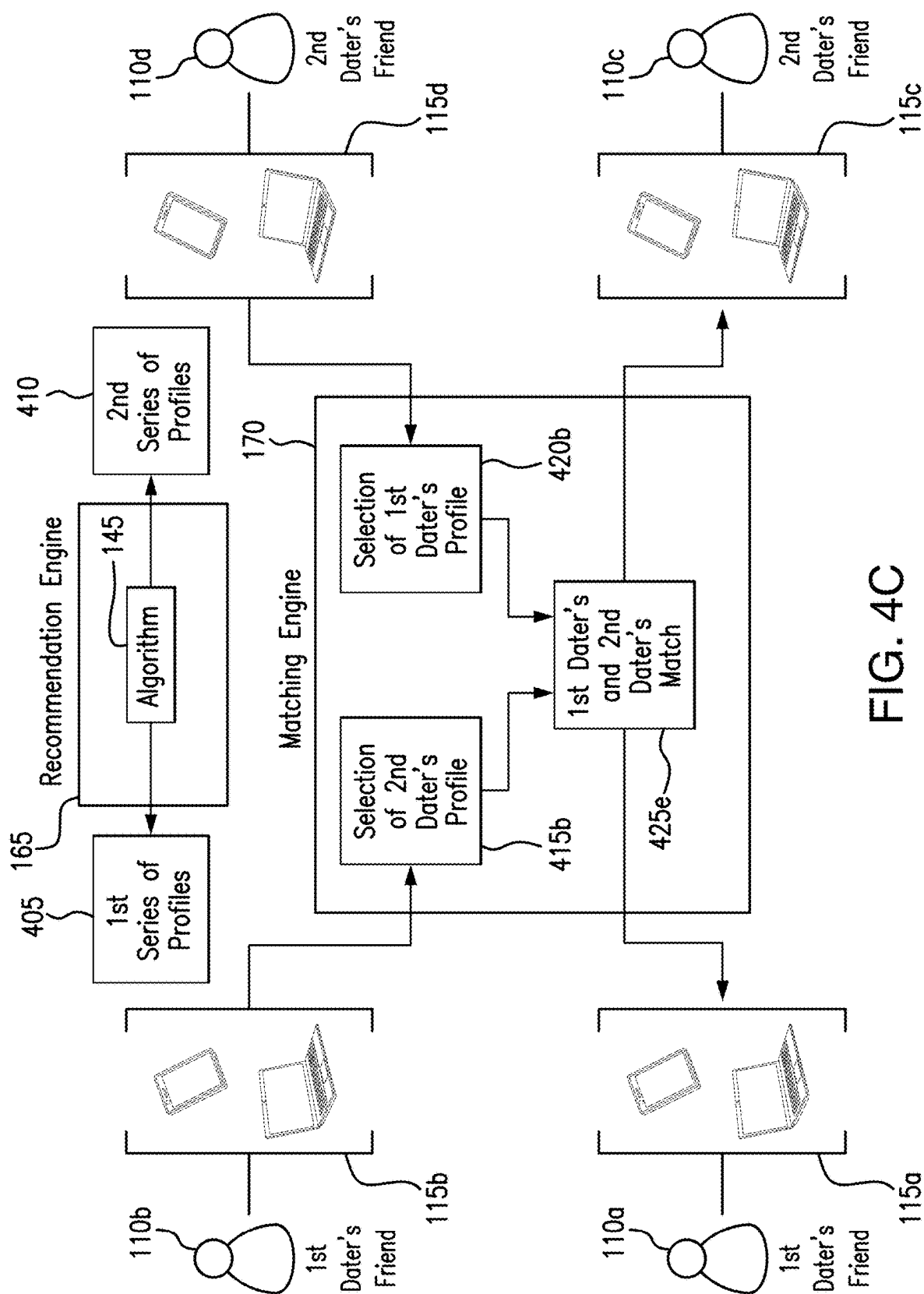


FIG. 4A





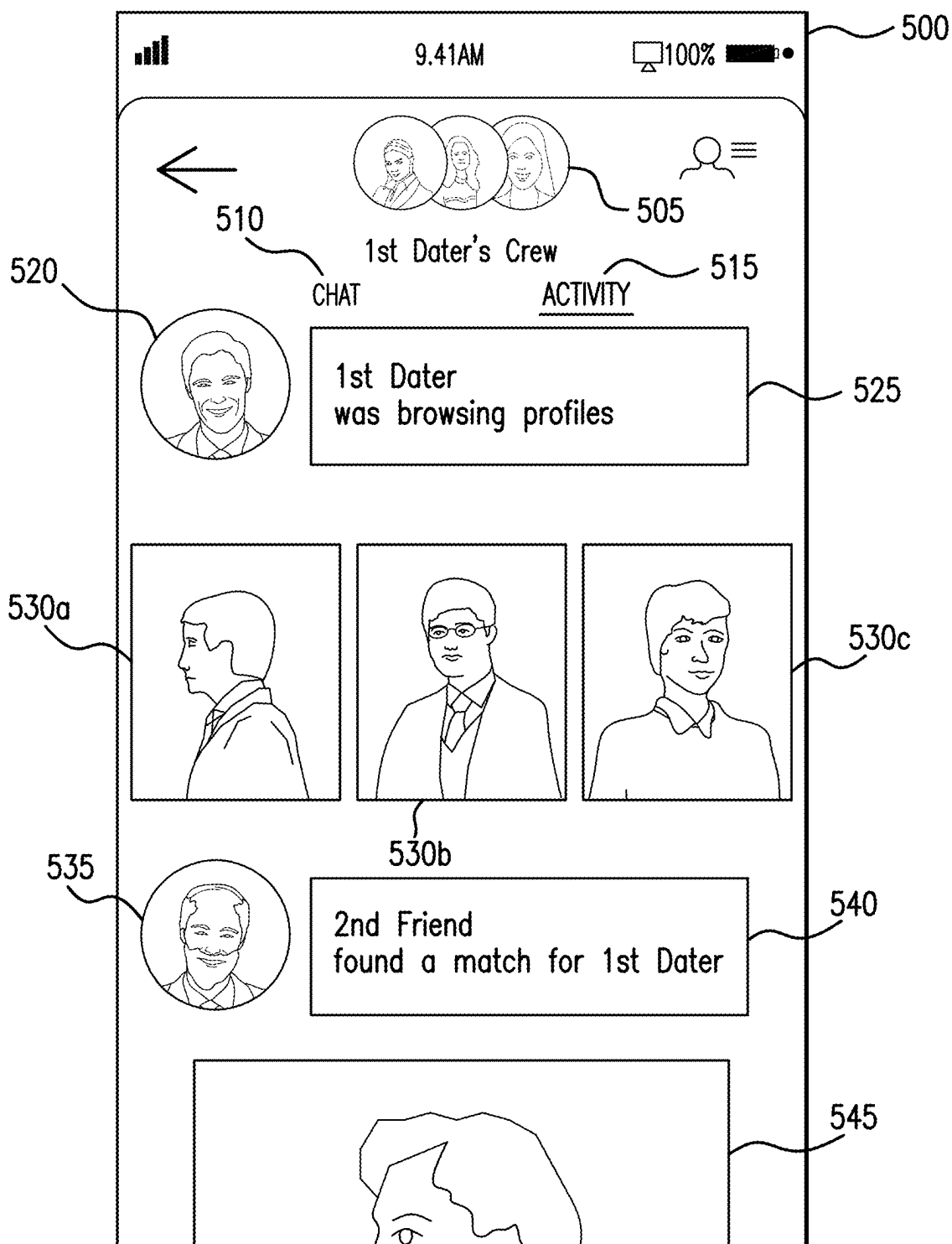


FIG. 5

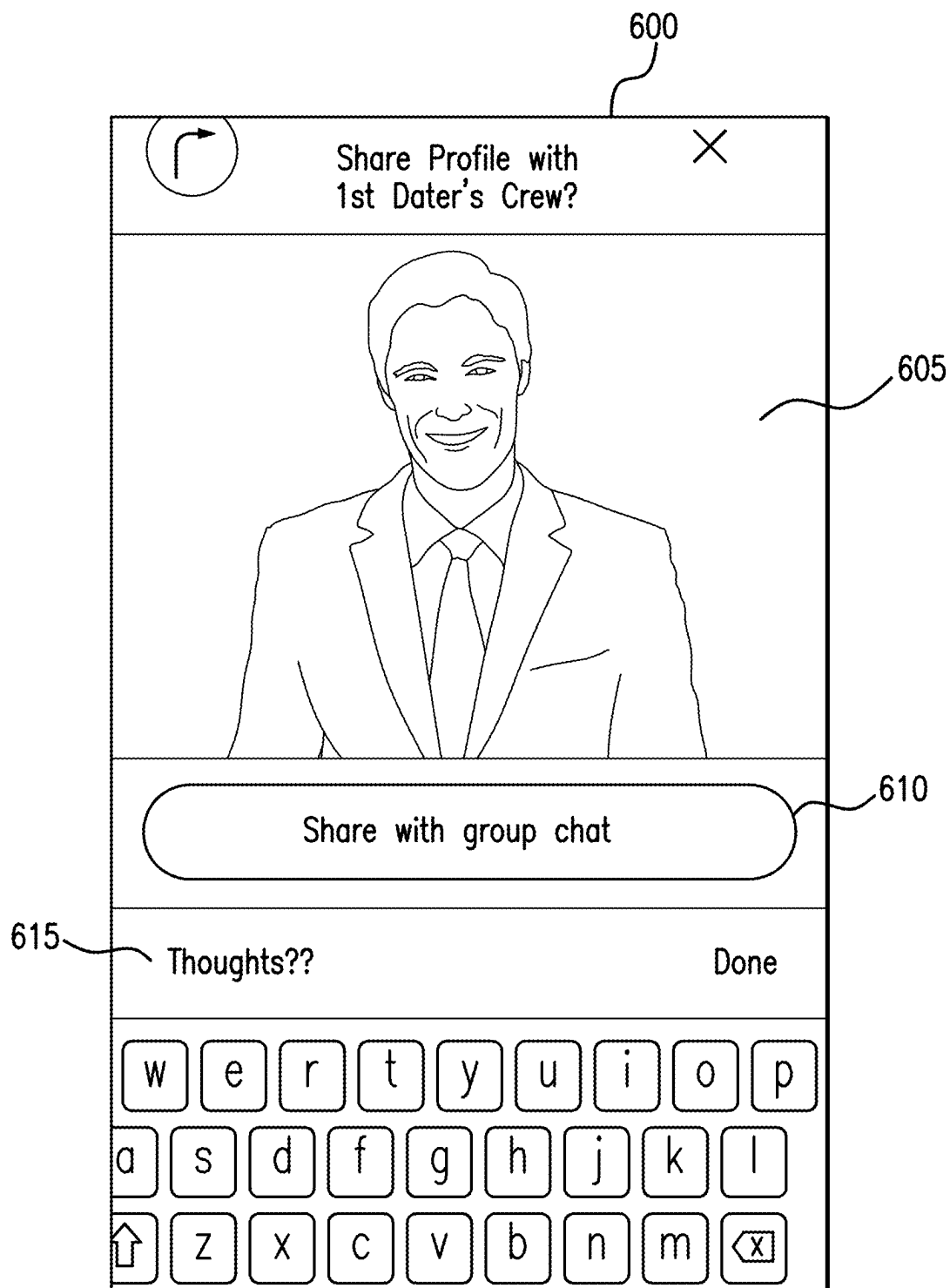


FIG. 6

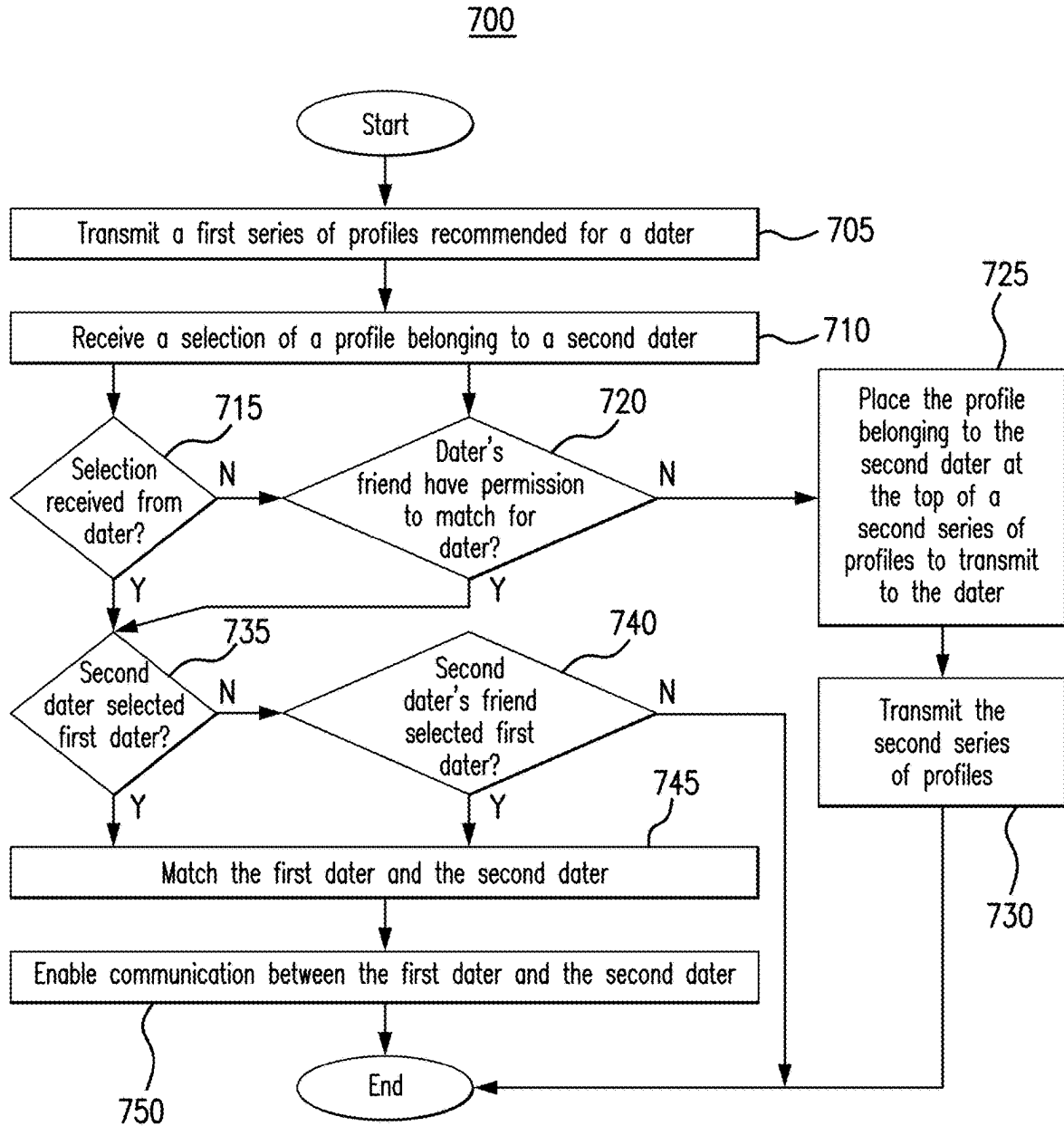


FIG. 7

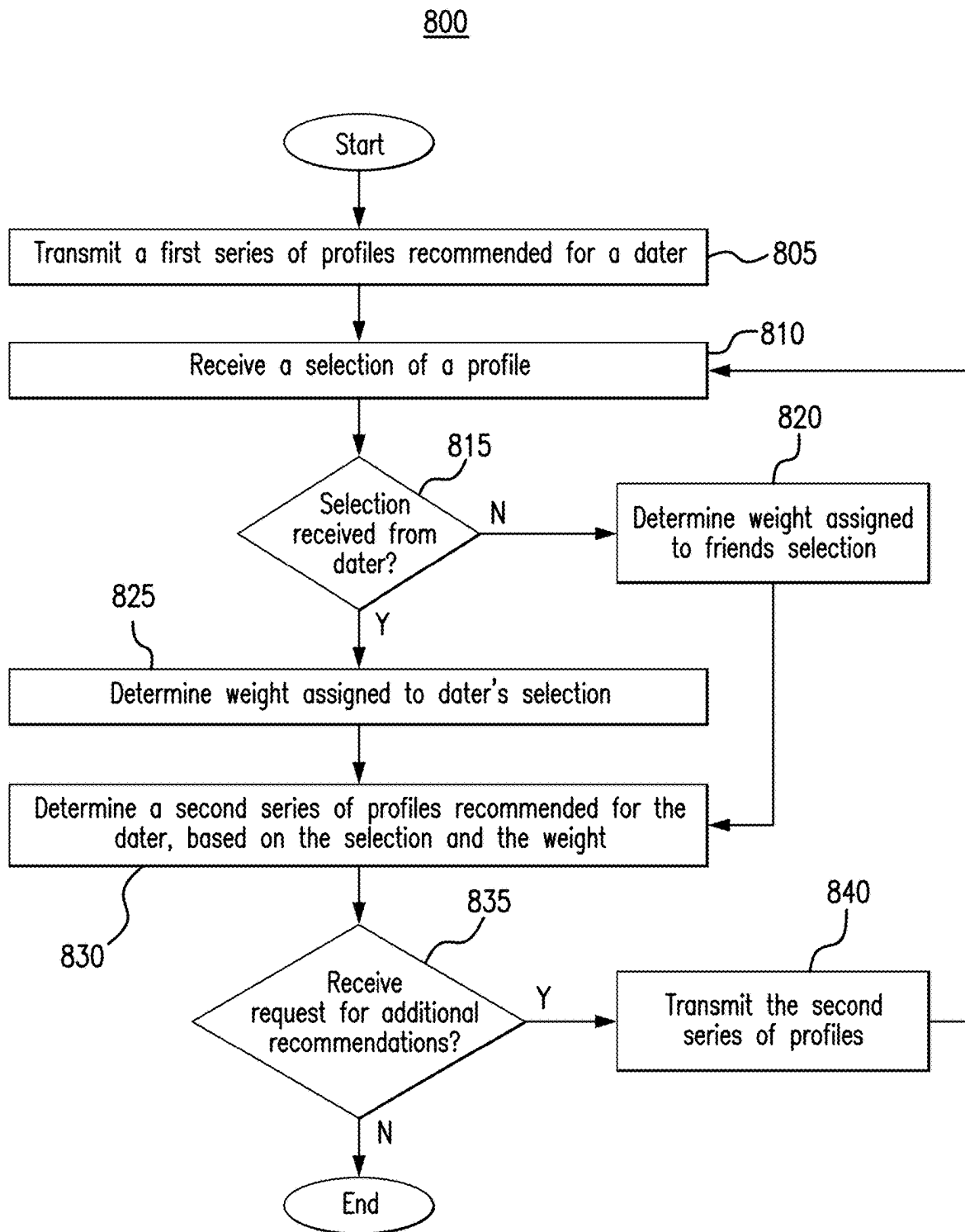


FIG. 8

SYSTEM AND METHOD FOR PROVIDING ENHANCED RECOMMENDATIONS BASED ON THIRD-PARTY OPINIONS

PRIORITY

[0001] This application is a continuation, under 35 U.S.C. § 120, of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/068,981 filed on Dec. 20, 2022, which is a continuation, under 35 U.S.C. § 120, of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/746,685 filed on Jan. 17, 2020, now U.S. Pat. No. 11,537,673 and entitled “*System and Method for Providing Enhanced Recommendations Based on Third-Party Opinions*” each of which are hereby incorporated by reference in their entirety.

TECHNICAL FIELD

[0002] This invention relates generally to the field of communications and, more particularly, to a system and method for providing enhanced recommendations based on third-party opinions.

BACKGROUND

[0003] Networking architectures, developed in communications environments, have grown increasingly complex in recent years. A multitude of protocols and configurations have been developed to accommodate a diverse group of end users having various networking needs. Many of these architectures have gained significant notoriety because they can offer the benefits of automation, convenience, management, and enhanced consumer selections. Using computing platforms with the networking architectures has allowed for increased communication, collaboration, and/or interaction. For example, certain network protocols may be used to allow an end user to connect online with other users who satisfy certain search requirements. These protocols may relate to job searches, person finding services, real estate searches, or online dating.

SUMMARY

[0004] This disclosure contemplates a matching tool that is designed to enable both singles and those in relationships to participate in the online-matching process. Users of the matching tool may register as either single, or in a relationship. Users who register as single may participate in the full experience offered by the matching tool, while users who register as in a relationship may participate in the matching process by attempting to generate matches for their single friends and/or by providing suggestions to their single friends. Certain embodiments of the matching tool are described below.

[0005] According to one embodiment, an apparatus includes an interface and a hardware processor communicatively coupled to the interface. The interface sends and receives data over a network. The hardware processor uses the interface to transmit a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles includes recommended profiles for a second user. The processor also uses the interface to receive a selection from the first user of a profile corresponding to a third user. The processor additionally uses the interface to transmit a second series of profiles to the third user. The second series of profiles includes recommended profiles for the third user. The processor further uses the interface to receive a selection from the third user of a profile corresponding to the second user. In response to receiving

the selection from the first user of the profile corresponding to the third user and receiving the selection from the third user of the profile corresponding to the second user, the processor enables communication between the second user and the third user.

[0006] According to another embodiment, a method includes transmitting a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles includes recommended profiles for a second user. The method also includes receiving a selection from the first user of a profile corresponding to a third user. The method additionally includes transmitting a second series of profiles to the third user. The second series of profiles includes recommended profiles for the third user. The method further includes receiving a selection from the third user of a profile corresponding to the second user. In response to receiving the selection from the first user of the profile corresponding to the third user and receiving the selection from the third user of the profile corresponding to the second user, the method includes enabling communication between the second user and the third user.

[0007] According to another embodiment, at least one computer-readable medium includes a plurality of instructions that, when executed by at least one processor, causes the at least one processor to transmit a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles include recommended profiles for a second user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions also causes the at least one processor to receive a selection from the first user of a profile corresponding to a third user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions additionally causes the at least one processor to transmit a second series of profiles to the third user. The second series of profiles includes recommended profiles for the third user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions further causes the at least one processor to receive a selection from the third user of a profile corresponding to the second user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions also causes the at least one processor to determine that the second user has authorized the first user to select profiles on behalf of the second user. In response to causing the at least one processor to receive the selection from the first user of the profile corresponding to the third user, receive the selection from the third user of the profile corresponding to the second user, and determine that the second user has authorized the first user to select profiles on behalf of the second user, when executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions additionally cause the processor to enable communication between the second user and the third user.

[0008] According to another embodiment, an apparatus includes an interface and a hardware processor communicatively coupled to the interface. The interface sends and receives data over a network. The hardware processor uses the interface to transmit a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles corresponds to recommendations of users for a second user. The processor also uses the interface to receive a selection from the first user of a first profile of the first series of profiles. In response to receiving the selection from the first user of the first profile of the first series of profiles, the processor determines, based at least in part on the selection from the first user of the first profile, a second series of profiles. The processor additionally uses the interface to transmit the second series of profiles to the second user.

[0009] According to yet another embodiment, a method includes transmitting a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles corresponds to recommendations of users for a second user. The method also includes receiving a selection from the first user of a first profile of the first series of profiles. In response to receiving the selection from the first user of the first profile of the first series of profiles, the method includes determining, based at least in part on the selection from the first user of the first profile, a second series of profiles. The method further includes transmitting the second series of profiles to the second user.

[0010] According to a further embodiment, at least one computer-readable medium includes a plurality of instructions that, when executed by at least one processor, causes the at least one processor to transmit a first series of profiles to a first user. The first series of profiles corresponds to recommendations of users for a second user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions also causes the at least one processor to receive a selection from the first user of a first profile of the first series of profiles. In response to causing the at least one processor to receive the selection from the first user of the first profile of the first series of profiles, when executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions additionally causes the at least one processor to determine, based at least in part on a first weight assigned to the first user and the selection from the first user of the first profile, a second series of profiles corresponding to recommendations of users for the second user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions further causes the at least one processor to transmit the second series of profiles to the second user. In response to causing the at least one processor to transmit the second series of profiles to the second user, when executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions also causes the at least one processor to receive a selection from the second user of a profile of the second series of profiles. In response to causing the at least one processor to receive the selection from the second user of the profile of the second series of profiles, when executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions additionally causes the at least one processor to determine, based at least in part on a second weight assigned to the second user and the selection from the second user of the profile of the second series of profiles, a third series of profiles corresponding to recommendations of users for the second user. When executed by the at least one processor, the plurality of instructions further causes the at least one processor to transmit the third series of profiles to the second user.

[0011] Certain embodiments provide one or more technical advantages. For example, an embodiment dynamically updates the profiles recommended to a user based on activity of the user as well as activity of the user's friends, acting on behalf of the user. As another example, an embodiment provides enhanced recommendations for a user by considering not only the user's preferences but also the preferences of the user's friends, acting on behalf of the user. In this manner, certain embodiments may decrease the processing and bandwidth resources expended by the system in providing recommendations to a user, prior to the user matching with and forming a successful relationship with another user offline. As a further example, an embodiment enables a user's friend to provide recommendations for the user and/or select profiles on behalf of the user without downloading an

application or registering with the matching system, by providing the friend access to the system through a rich media component embedded in a text message. Certain embodiments may include none, some, or all of the above technical advantages. One or more other technical advantages may be readily apparent to one skilled in the art from the figures, descriptions, and claims included herein.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0012] For a more complete understanding of the present disclosure, reference is now made to the following description, taken in conjunction with the accompanying drawings, in which:

[0013] FIG. 1 illustrates an example system;

[0014] FIG. 2A illustrates a registration page of a graphical user interface generated by the profile generator of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1;

[0015] FIG. 2B illustrates an example of the behavior of the profile generator of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1;

[0016] FIGS. 3A through 3C illustrate examples of the behavior of the recommendation engine of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1, in response to receiving profile selections from a dater or one of the dater's friends;

[0017] FIGS. 4A through 4C illustrate examples of the behavior of the matching engine of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1, in response to receiving profile selections from a dater or one of the dater's friends;

[0018] FIG. 5 presents an example activity feed generated by the feed generator of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1;

[0019] FIG. 6 presents an example of a graphical user interface generated by the chatting engine of the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1 and used by a user of the system to share another user's profile in a group chat;

[0020] FIG. 7 presents a flowchart illustrating an example method by which the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1 may generate a match between a pair of daters in the system; and

[0021] FIG. 8 presents a flowchart illustrating an example method by which the matching tool of the system of FIG. 1 may generate recommendations of profiles belonging to users who are potentially compatible with a given dater registered with the tool.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION:

[0022] Embodiments of the present disclosure and its advantages may be understood by referring to FIGS. 1 through 8 of the drawings, like numerals being used for like and corresponding parts of the various drawings.

[0023] In a typical online-matching system, profiles that include particular sets of attributes related to participants in the system may be used to facilitate matching. As an example, in the online dating context, the profiles might include attributes such as age, education, and interests. Typical online-matching systems may use such attributes to identify pairs of potentially compatible daters and to recommend such daters to one another. For example, a typical online-matching system might generate recommendations by comparing various attributes from each dater's profile, to compute algorithmic estimates of compatibility scores between pairs of daters. As another example, an online-matching system may generate recommendations of poten-

tially compatible profiles for a dater based on the similarity of the recommended profiles to those profiles previously recommended to the dater and for which the dater has indicated a preference.

[0024] While conventional online-matching systems may rely on a number of different algorithms to generate recommendations, a common feature of such systems lies in the fact that the daters themselves are ultimately responsible for selecting matches from among the presented recommendations. For example, a conventional matching system will only match a first dater with a second dater if both the first dater indicates a positive preference for the second dater and the second dater indicates a positive preference for the first dater.

[0025] However, in the real world, individuals in long-term relationships frequently participate in the dating lives of their single friends. For example, individuals in relationships often set up their single friends on blind dates, and singles often consult their friends for opinions on dating prospects. Indeed, singles may even attempt to include their non-single friends in conventional online dating experiences, by sharing screen captures of profile pictures they have viewed in a conventional online dating system with their non-single friends, outside of the online-matching system.

[0026] Accordingly, this disclosure contemplates a matching tool that adds to the experience provided by conventional online-matching systems by enabling both singles and those in relationships to participate in the online-matching process. Users of the matching tool may register as either single, or in a relationship. Users who register as single may participate in the full experience offered by the matching tool. This includes receiving profile recommendations, selecting profiles to match with, and chatting with matches, among other activities. A single user may also invite other users, such as those registered as in a relationship, to connect with the single user, thereby becoming his/her friends within the tool. The single user may then grant his/her friends various permissions, including, for example, the permission to select profiles on the single user's behalf, the permission to chat with potential matches on the single user's behalf, and/or the permission to edit the single user's profile, among others. In certain embodiments, a user may grant his/her friends friend-specific permissions. For example, the user may assign a first set of permissions to a first friend and a second set of permissions to a second friend, where the second set of permissions may be different from the first set of permissions. In some embodiments, a user may assign his/her friends to a team or group, and then set group-specific permissions for the team/group. For example, the user may assign each of his/her friends to a group and then assign a single set of permissions to every member of the group. A user who registers with the tool as "in a relationship" may connect with multiple single friends and may participate in the online-matching system according to the permissions set by his/her single friends. For example, a user who registers with the tool as "in a relationship" may participate in the online-matching system by attempting to generate matches for his/her single friends and/or providing suggestions of profiles to his/her single friends.

[0027] FIG. 1 illustrates an example system 100. As seen in FIG. 1, system 100 includes matching tool 105, user(s) 110, device(s) 115, network 120, and database 125. As used throughout this disclosure, each user of users 110a through

110e may correspond to a user who is acting as a dater, a friend of a dater, or both a dater and a friend of one or more other daters. Accordingly, when discussing actions performed by a given user 110a, this disclosure refers to the role of user 110a at the time user 110a performed each action. For example, this disclosure will refer to user 110a as dater 110a when user 110a is seeking matches for him/herself, communicating with potential matches, and/or performing any other actions associated with a dater. As another example, this disclosure will refer to user 110a as friend 110a when user 110a is performing actions on behalf of a single friend. Such references to specific roles of users 110 are in no way meant to limit the potential roles of users 110. While this disclosure contemplates any number of users 110, acting as daters and/or friends of daters, for simplicity, FIG. 1 illustrates users 110 as including first dater 110a, first friend 110b of first dater 110a, second dater 110c, first friend 110d of second dater 110c, and second friend 110e of second dater 110c.

[0028] Generally, matching tool 105 generates recommendations for first dater 110a and second dater 110c, consisting of profiles 130 of other, potentially compatible daters, and transmits such recommendations to the daters and their registered friends, for selection therefrom. In this manner matching tool 105 enables both daters 110a and 110c as well as friends 110b, 110d, and 110e to participate in the online dating process for daters 110a and 110c.

[0029] As an example, consider dater 110a. Matching tool 105 generates recommendations of other, potentially compatible daters, and presents a series of profiles 130 belonging to the potentially compatible daters to dater 110a and/or friend 110b of dater 110a for selection therefrom. For example, in certain embodiments, friend 110b may receive a series of recommendations for first dater 110a that includes profile 130c belonging to second dater 110c. In response to viewing profile 130c, friend 110b may believe that second dater 110c is likely compatible with first dater 110a (e.g., friend 110b may believe that the potential exists for first dater 110a and second dater 110c to enter into a successful dating relationship offline). Accordingly, friend 110b may select profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c, in the hopes of generating a match in the system between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. If second dater 110c, friend 110d of second dater 110c, and/or friend 110e of second dater 110c similarly selects profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, as a potential match for second dater 110c, matching tool 105 will generate a match between first dater 110a and second dater 110c, enabling communication between the two daters. In this manner, matching tool 105 enables both dater 110a and friend 110b of dater 110a to participate in the matching process for dater 110a.

[0030] As another example, in certain embodiments, rather than being able to generate matches for first dater 110a, friend 110b of first dater 110a may be able to suggest profiles to first dater 110a that friend 110b thinks first dater 110a should attempt to match with. For example, in response to receiving a series of recommendations for first dater 110a that includes profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c, friend 110b may select profile 130c, thereby generating an indication to first dater 110a that friend 110b thinks that first dater 110a should select profile 130c (e.g., friend 110b thinks that first dater 110a and second dater 110c are likely compatible). In certain embodiments, the indication to first dater 110a that friend 110b thinks that first dater 110a should

select profile 130c may correspond to matching tool 105 reordering the series of recommendations presented to first dater 110a, such that profile 130c is located earlier in the series of recommendations than if friend 110b had not selected profile 130. For example, matching tool 105 may reorder the series of recommendations such that profile 130c is the first profile presented to dater 110a. In some embodiments, the indication to first dater 110a that friend 110b thinks that first dater 110a should select profile 130c may correspond to an indication placed on profile 130c, as presented to first dater 110a. For example, profile 130c, as presented to first dater 110a, may include an icon or a statement such as “friend 110b thinks that you and dater 110c would be a great match,” or any similar phrase indicating that friend 110b has suggested profile 130c to first dater 110a. The manner by which matching tool 105 generates recommendations for users 110 and matches users 110 with one another is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIGS. 3 and 4.

[0031] Devices 115 may be used by users 110 to receive incoming messages 185 and to send outgoing messages 190. While illustrated in FIG. 1 as incoming messages 185 passing directly from matching tool 105 to devices 115 and outgoing messages 190 passing directly from devices 115 to matching tool 105, this disclosure contemplates that the exchange of messages 185 and 190 between matching tool 105 and devices 115 is facilitated by network 120. For example, matching tool 105 may transmit incoming messages 185 to devices 115 over network 120. Similarly, devices 115 may transmit outgoing messages 190 to matching tool 105 over network 120.

[0032] This disclosure contemplates that incoming messages 185 may include any messages received by devices 115. Similarly, outgoing messages 190 may include any messages transmitted by devices 115. As an example, incoming message 185 may include a series of profiles 130, recommended for dater 110a and received by device 115a of dater 110a and/or device 115b of friend 110b of dater 110a. In this example, outgoing message 190 may then include one or more selections of profiles 130, transmitted by device 115a of dater 110a and/or device 115b of friend 110b of dater 110a, and selected from the series of profiles 130 recommended for dater 110a. This form of incoming message 185 and outgoing message 190 is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIGS. 3 and 4.

[0033] As another example, incoming messages 185 may include requests for information from users 110, used by matching tool 105 to generate profiles 130. Outgoing messages 190 may then include the information submitted by users 110, in response to requests 185. For example, incoming messages 185 may include requests for users’ names, genders, ages, birthdates, and/or any other personal information, and outgoing messages 190 may include responses, containing such personal information. The manner by which matching tool 105 generates requests 185 for personal information and creates user profiles 130 using responses 190 is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIGS. 2A and 2B.

[0034] As another example, incoming messages 185 and outgoing messages 190 may include messages originating from a first user 110a or 110b and destined for a second user 110c, 110d, and/or 110e (or vice versa), where matching tool 105 is used to facilitate communication between first user 110a or 110b and second user 110c, 110d, and/or 110e. For

example, first user 110a may transmit message 190 to matching tool 105, for ultimate receipt by second user 110c. Matching tool 105 may then transmit the contents of message 190 to second user 110c, as message 185. In a similar manner, messages 190 may include messages originating from first dater 110a and destined for friend 110b (or vice versa). For example, incoming messages 185 and outgoing messages 190 may include portions of a chat session between any combination of first dater 110a, first friend 110b of first dater 110a, second dater 110c, first friend 110d of second dater 110c, and second friend 110e of second dater 110c, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 6.

[0035] As a further example, incoming messages 185 may include information relating to the activities of first dater 110a and/or first dater’s friend 110b, with respect to matching tool 105. For example, incoming message 185 may include an activity feed, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 5.

[0036] Devices 115 include any appropriate device for communicating with components of system 100 over network 120. For example, device 115 may be or may be accompanied by a telephone, a mobile phone, a computer, a laptop, a tablet, a server, an automated assistant, and/or a virtual reality or augmented reality headset or sensor, or other device. This disclosure contemplates device 115 being any appropriate device for sending and receiving communications over network 120. For example, devices 115 may include any appropriate devices for receiving incoming messages 185 and transmitting outgoing messages 190. As an example, and not by way of limitation, device 115 may be a computer, a laptop, a wireless or cellular telephone, an electronic notebook, a personal digital assistant, a tablet, or any other device capable of receiving, processing, storing, and/or communicating information with other components of system 100. Device 115 may also include a user interface, such as a display, a microphone, keypad, or other appropriate terminal equipment usable by user 110. In some embodiments, an application executed by device 115 may perform the functions described herein. In certain embodiments, devices 115 may communicate with matching tool 105 through network 120 via a web interface.

[0037] Network 120 facilitates communication between and amongst the various components of system 100. This disclosure contemplates network 120 being any suitable network operable to facilitate communication between the components of system 100. Network 120 may include any interconnecting system capable of transmitting audio, video, signals, data, messages, or any combination of the preceding. Network 120 may include all or a portion of a public switched telephone network (PSTN), a public or private data network, a local area network (LAN), a metropolitan area network (MAN), a wide area network (WAN), a local, regional, or global communication or computer network, such as the Internet, a wireline or wireless network, an enterprise intranet, or any other suitable communication link, including combinations thereof, operable to facilitate communication between the components.

[0038] Database 125 may store a set of user profiles 130. Database may contain any number of user profiles 130a, 130b, 130c, through 130n. User profiles 130 define or represent features of users 110. Profiles 130 may be available to the general public, to those who are members of the online dating system, and/or to a specific category of those

members of the online dating system. Profiles **130** may contain information that was solicited from users **110** when users **110** set up their online dating accounts or was otherwise input by such users into their profiles, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 2B. Profiles **130** may include general information such as age, height, gender, and occupation, as well as detailed information that may include the users' interests, likes/dislikes, personal feelings, and/or outlooks on the world. This disclosure contemplates that in certain embodiments, profiles **130a** and **130c**, assigned to daters **110a** and **110c**, respectively, may include more detailed information than profiles **130b**, **130d**, and **130e**, assigned to friends **110b**, **110d**, and **110e** of daters **110a** and **110c**. Profiles **130a** and **130c** may include more detailed information than profiles **130b**, **130d**, and **130e**, because the information contained in profiles **130a** and **130c** may be used by matching tool **105** to facilitate matching between daters **110a** and **110c**. The information contained in profiles **130b**, **130d**, and **130e** may also be used by daters **110a** and **110c** to locate and identify their friends in the online dating system.

[0039] As seen in FIG. 1, matching tool **105** includes processor **135**, memory **140**, and interface **142**. This disclosure contemplates processor **135**, memory **140**, and interface **142** being configured to perform any of the functions of matching tool **105** described herein. Generally, matching tool **105** implements profile generator **160**, recommendation engine **165**, matching engine **170**, feed generator **175**, and chatting engine **180**. Profile generator **160** is used to generate user profiles **130**, stored in database **125**, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 2. Recommendation engine **165** is used to generate recommendations for a given dater **110a** of other, potentially compatible daters **110c**, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 3. Matching engine **170** is used to receive feedback from users **110** of the recommendations for daters **110a** and **110c**, provided by recommendation engine **165** to users **110**, and to match daters **110a** and **110c** based on this feedback, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 4. Feed generator **175** is used to generate activity feeds, based on the activities of users **110** with respect to matching tool **105**, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 5.

[0040] Chatting engine **180** is used to facilitate communication between users **110** of matching tool **105**. This disclosure contemplates that chatting engine **180** may be configured to facilitate any suitable type of communication amongst users **110**. As an example, chatting engine **180** may be configured to facilitate communication between first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** in response to matching engine **170** generating match **425** between first dater **110a** and second dater **110c**. For example, chatting engine **180** may be configured to receive message **190** transmitted by dater **110a**, for ultimate receipt by dater **110c**. In response to receiving message **190**, chatting engine **180** may be configured to transmit the contents of message **190** to dater **110c**, as message **185**. In certain embodiments in which second dater **110c** has granted friend **110d** permission to chat with second dater **110c**'s matches on his/her behalf, chatting engine **180** may be configured to facilitate communication between first dater **110a** and friend **110d** of second dater **110c**, in response to matching engine **170** generating match **425** between first dater **110a** and second dater **110c**. In some embodiments, first dater **110a** may be aware that he/she is

chatting with friend **110d** of second dater **110c**, rather than second dater **110c**. In certain embodiments, first dater **110a** may not be aware that he/she is chatting with friend **110d** of second dater **110c**, rather than second dater **110c**.

[0041] As another example, chatting engine **180** may be configured to facilitate communication between first dater **110a**, second dater **110c**, and first friend **110b** who selected profile **130c**, belonging to second dater **110c**, on behalf of first dater **110a**. For example, first friend **110b** may use chatting engine **180** to make an introduction between first dater **110a** and second dater **110c**. Here, chatting engine **180** may be configured to receive message **190**, transmitted by friend **110b**, for ultimate receipt by both daters **110a** and **110c**. In response to receiving message **190**, chatting engine **180** may be configured to transmit the contents of message **190** to both first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** as message **185**. As a specific example, first friend **110b** may use chatting engine **180** in this manner to present first dater **110a** and second dater **110b** with an icebreaker question. In certain embodiments, friend **110b** of first dater **110a** may only be permitted to communicate with second dater **110c** if first dater **110a** has set permissions **150b**, belonging to friend **110b**, to allow for such communication.

[0042] As another example, chatting engine **180** may be configured to facilitate communication between dater **110a** and his/her friends **110** or a subset of his/her friends **110**. For example, in certain embodiments, chatting engine **180** may be configured to generate a group chat amongst the members of a team or group of friends **110** created by dater **110a**. This group chat may be accessible to the members of dater **110a**'s team/group through a graphical user interface which may be generated by chatting engine **180** and displayed on devices **115** belonging to the members of dater **110a**'s team/group. In certain embodiments, chatting engine **180** may also be configured to facilitate communication between a subset of the members of a team/group belonging to dater **110a**. For example, team/group members **110b**, **110f**, and **110g** may generate a chatting session amongst one another to discuss a profile **130** that one or more of the team/group members is considering sharing with dater **110a**, prior to sharing profile **130** with dater **110a**.

[0043] As another example, in certain embodiments, in response to dater **110a** inviting friend **110b** to connect with dater **110a** within matching tool **105** (e.g., inviting friend **110b** to join dater **110a**'s friend list), dater **110a** may add friend **110b** to a group chat. This disclosure contemplates that dater **110a** may create any number of group chats and assign his/her friends to such group chats in any manner. For example, dater **110a** may create a first group chat for his/her college friends, a second group chat for his/her work friends, and a third group chat for his/her closest friends, where the membership of the third group chat may overlap with the membership of the first and/or second group chats. In certain embodiments, members of a group chat may share profiles **130** with one another using the group chat. This aspect of chatting engine **180** is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 6.

[0044] In certain embodiments, chatting engine **180** may additionally be configured to facilitate communication between groups of users **110** with common interests. Such groups may be self-generated by users **110**, or moderated groups generated by system administrators. As an example, a user **110** may generate group for dachshund lovers, which any other users may join. The formation of such groups may

be desirable as they may provide an additional avenue for daters **110a** and friends **110b** of daters **110a** to discover potential matches for daters **110a**.

[0045] Chatting engine **180** may be a software module stored in memory **140** and executed by processor **135**. An example algorithm for chatting engine **180** is as follows: (1) receive message **190** transmitted by user **110a** and destined for user **110d**; (2) determine that user **110a** is permitted to communicate with user **110d** (e.g., user **110a** is a member of a team or group created by user **110d** (or vice versa), user **110a** and user **110d** have been matched by matching tool **105**, user **110d** is a member of a team or group belonging to user **110c** with whom user **110a** has matched (or vice versa), and/or user **110a** and user **110d** are members of a group chat based on a common interest); (3) transmit the contents of message **190** in message **185** to user **110d**. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for chatting engine **180**, this disclosure contemplates that chatting engine **180** may use any algorithm operable to facilitate communication between users **110**. For example, the algorithm used by chatting engine **180** may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by chatting engine **180** may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0046] Processor **135** may be any electronic circuitry, including, but not limited to microprocessors, application specific integrated circuits (ASIC), application specific instruction set processor (ASIP), and/or state machines, that communicatively couples to memory **140** and interface **142** and controls the operation of matching tool **105**. Processor **135** may be 8-bit, 16-bit, 32-bit, 64-bit or of any other suitable architecture. Processor **135** may include an arithmetic logic unit (ALU) for performing arithmetic and logic operations, processor registers that supply operands to the ALU and store the results of ALU operations, and a control unit that fetches instructions from memory and executes them by directing the coordinated operations of the ALU, registers and other components. Processor **135** may include other hardware and software that operates to control and process information. Processor **135** executes software stored on memory **140** to perform any of the functions described herein. Processor **135** controls the operation and administration of matching tool **105** by processing information received from network **120**, device(s) **115**, interface **142**, and memory **140**. Processor **135** may be a programmable logic device, a microcontroller, a microprocessor, any suitable processing device, or any suitable combination of the preceding. Processor **135** is not limited to a single processing device and may encompass multiple processing devices.

[0047] Memory **140** may store, either permanently or temporarily, data, operational software, or other information for processor **135**. Memory **140** may include any one or a combination of volatile or non-volatile local or remote devices suitable for storing information. For example, memory **140** may include random access memory (RAM), read only memory (ROM), magnetic storage devices, optical storage devices, or any other suitable information storage device or a combination of these devices. The software represents any suitable set of instructions, logic, or code embodied in a computer-readable storage medium. For example, the software may be embodied in memory **140**, a disk, a CD, or a flash drive. In particular embodiments, the

software may include an application executable by processor **135** to perform one or more of the functions described herein.

[0048] In certain embodiments, memory **140** may also store recommendation algorithm **145**, a set of friend permissions **150**, and/or a set of algorithm weights **155**. Recommendation algorithm **145** is an algorithm configured to generate, for a given dater **110a**, recommendations of profiles **130** belonging to other daters **110c**, who may potentially be compatible with dater **110a**. This disclosure contemplates that recommendation algorithm **145** may determine potential compatibility in any suitable manner. As an example, recommendation algorithm **145** may determine that first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** are potentially compatible based on similarities between profile **130a**, belonging to first dater **110a**, and profile **130c**, belonging to second dater **110c**. As another example, recommendation algorithm **145** may determine that first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** are potentially compatible based on previous profile preferences expressed by first dater **110a** and/or second dater **110c**. As a further example, recommendation algorithm **145** may determine that first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** are potentially compatible by computing attractiveness scores for each of first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** and determining that first dater **110a** and second dater **110c** have similar attractiveness scores, under the assumption that people are more likely to match with people of similar attractiveness. Additional details and examples of recommendation algorithm **145** are presented in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 3.

[0049] The set of algorithm weights **155** may include one or more weights assigned to each of users **110a** through **110e**. For example, first weight **155a** may be assigned to first dater **110a**, second weight **155b** may be assigned to first friend **110b** of first dater **110a**, third weight **155c** may be assigned to second dater **110c**, fourth weight **155d** may be assigned to first friend **110d** of second dater **110c**, and fifth weight **155e** may be assigned to second friend **110e** of second dater **110c**. Each weight **155a** through **155d** may indicate the relative importance that matching algorithm **145** should place on previous profile preferences expressed by users **110**. As an example, a value for first weight **155a** of 1.0 and a value for second weight **155b** of 0.5 may indicate that matching algorithm **145** should place twice as much importance on a previous profile preference received from first dater **110a**, and indicating that first dater **110a** would like to match with a dater **110** associated with profile **130f**, as compared to a previous profile preference received from friend **110b** of first dater **110a**, and indicating that friend **110b** would like first dater **110a** to match with a dater **110** associated with profile **130f**, when determining future profile recommendations for first dater **110a**. As another example, a value for fourth weight **155d** of 0.8 and a value for fifth weight **155e** of 0.4 may indicate that matching algorithm **145** should place greater importance on previous profile preferences received from first friend **110d** of second dater **110c** than on previous profile preferences received from second friend **110e** of second dater **110c**, when determining future profile recommendations for second dater **110c**. The use of weights **155** is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 3.

[0050] Friend permissions **150** may include permissions granted by daters **110** to their friends, which indicate the permissible actions that the friends may take when acting on

behalf of daters 110. For example, first dater 110a may grant friend 110b permissions 150b, indicating that friend 110b may attempt to match with other users on behalf of dater 110a and to communicate with other daters 110c on behalf of first dater 110a. This disclosure contemplates that friend permissions 150 may include any suitable permissions that a dater 110a may grant to his/her friends. For example, permissions 150 may include permissions to select profiles 130 in an attempt to match dater 110a with other daters; suggest profiles 130 to dater 110a; edit profile 130a, assigned to dater 110a; suggest edits to profile 130a, assigned to dater 110a; communicate with matches generated for dater 110a on behalf of dater 110a; communicate with matches generated for dater 110a as a friend of dater 110a; view the behavior of dater 110a while interacting with matching tool 105; and/or any other appropriate permissions that dater 110a may grant to his/her friends. The use of friend permissions 150 is described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIGS. 2 through 5.

[0051] Interface 142 represents any suitable device operable to receive information from network 120, transmit information through network 120, perform suitable processing of the information, communicate to other devices, or any combination of the preceding. For example, interface 142 transmits messages 185 to devices 115 and receives messages 190 from devices 115. As another example, interface 142 may facilitate the exchange of messages between users 110, for example, by receiving a message transmitted by user 110a for ultimate receipt by user 110c and then transmitting the message to user 110c. Interface 142 represents any port or connection, real or virtual, including any suitable hardware and/or software, including protocol conversion and data processing capabilities, to communicate through a LAN, WAN, or other communication systems that allows matching tool 105 to exchange information with devices 115 and/or other components of system 100 via network 120.

[0052] Modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to the systems described herein without departing from the scope of the invention. For example, system 100 may include any number of users 110, devices 115, networks 120, and databases 125. The components may be integrated or separated. Moreover, the operations described above may be performed by more, fewer, or other components. Additionally, the operations may be performed using any suitable logic comprising software, hardware, and/or other logic. As used in this document, “each” refers to each member of a set or each member of a subset of a set.

[0053] FIGS. 2A and 2B illustrate the process by which matching tool 105 registers users 110 and generates profiles 130 for users 110. In certain embodiments, users 110 (including both daters and friends of daters) register with matching tool 105 prior receiving recommendations from the tool. The registration process may involve submitting information to matching tool 105, which is then used by the tool to generate profiles 130 for the users.

[0054] FIG. 2A illustrates an example graphical user interface 205, displayed on a device 115 of user 110, and used by user 110 to begin the process of registering with matching tool 105. Matching tool 105 may present user 110 with graphical user interface 205 in response to several different scenarios. As an example, a user 110, interested in participating in the online dating experience, may access the Internet via device 115 and travel to a website managed by matching tool 105. The website may then present graphical

user interface 205 to user 110. As another example, a user 110 may download an application to device 115, through which user 110 may interact with matching tool 105. In response to accessing the application for the first time, the application may present graphical user interface 205 to user 110.

[0055] As another example, matching tool 105 may transmit a message 185 to an existing user (e.g., 110a), requesting that user 110a invite his/her friends to participate in the online dating experience. For example, matching tool 105 may first transmit a message 185 to user 110a requesting that user 110a provide matching tool 105 with access to the contacts stored on device 115 of user 110a. If user 110a transmits a response 190 to matching tool 105 granting matching tool 105 permission to access the contacts stored on device 115, matching tool 105 may then transmit a list of contacts to device 115, from which user 110a may choose to invite one or more of the listed contacts to participate in the online dating experience. For example, in response to receiving the list of contacts, user 110a may indicate to matching tool 105 that he/she wishes to invite a first contact (e.g., 110b) to register with matching tool 105. In certain embodiments, in response to receiving an indication from user 110a indicating that he/she wishes to invite first contact 110b to register with matching tool 105, matching tool 105 may automatically generate and transmit to first contact 110b sign-up request 250, in the form of an SMS and/or email message that includes a link through which first contact 110b may access graphical user interface 205, to begin the registration process. In some embodiments, rather than automatically transmitting an SMS and/or email message, matching tool 105 may access an SMS and/or email application on device 115 of user 110a and pre-populate an SMS and/or email message to first contact 110b, with a link through which first contact 110b may access graphical user interface 205. User 110a may then choose to transmit the pre-populated SMS and/or email message to first contact 110b.

[0056] In certain embodiments, in addition to or instead of requesting access to the contacts stored on device 115 of user 110a, matching tool 105 may request access to one or more applications installed on device 115, through which user 110a may communicate with other individuals. For example, matching tool 105 may request access to one or more applications such as WECHAT, WHATSAPP, LINE, FACEBOOK, INSTAGRAM, LINKEDIN, or any other application through which user 110a may communicate with other individuals. If user 110a grants matching tool 105 access to any of these communication applications, matching tool 105 may access user 110a's friend lists, stored in the application(s), and generate invites, as described above, for one or more individuals stored in the friend lists. These invites may then be communicated through the application (s) to the individuals.

[0057] As illustrated in FIG. 2A, in certain embodiments, prior to receiving recommendations from matching tool 105, matching tool 105 may request that users 110 self-identify as either single or in a relationship. For example, graphical user interface 205 may include a pair of interactive buttons 210 and 215, through which user 110 may specify whether he/she is single or is in a relationship. User 110 may select button 210 to indicate that he/she is single, or user 110 may select button 215 to indicate that he/she is in a relationship.

[0058] If user 110a registers as “single,” matching tool 105 treats user 110a as an active dater and may provide user 110a with access to the full set of features offered by the online dating experience created by matching tool 105. For example, dater 110a may receive profile recommendations, select profiles to match with, and chat with matches, among other activities. Dater 110a may also perform any of these functions on behalf of his/her single friends, provided these single friends have granted dater 110a permission to do so. Additionally, profile 130a, belonging to dater 110a, may be viewable and selectable by other users 110.

[0059] If user 110b registers as “in a relationship,” matching tool 105 may limit the activities that user 110b may perform while interacting with the tool to only those activities that may be performed by a friend of a dater. For example, in certain embodiments, friend 110b may not receive any profile recommendations for him/herself, or match him/herself with any other users 110 (e.g., profile 130b, belonging to friend 110b, may not be selectable by other users 110 seeking to generate matches for daters 110a and 110c). Instead, friend 110b may act on behalf of daters 110a who have granted permissions 150b to friend 110b to do so. For example, dater 110a may grant friend 110b permissions 150b that include the permission to: (1) select profiles 130 in an attempt to match other users 110 with dater 110a; (2) suggest profiles 130 to dater 110a; (3) edit profile 130a, assigned to dater 110a; (4) suggest edits of profile 130a to dater 110a; (5) communicate with matches generated for dater 110a on behalf of dater 110a; (6) communicate with matches generated for dater 110a as friend 110b of dater 110a; (7) view the behavior of dater 110a while interacting with matching tool 105a; and/or (8) any other appropriate permissions that dater 110a may grant to friend 110b.

[0060] This disclosure contemplates that a single user 110c may grant friend 110d permission to act on his/her behalf in any suitable manner. As an example, in certain embodiments, in response to inviting friend 110d to participate in the online dating experience generated by matching tool 105 (e.g., inviting friend 110d to connect through matching tool 105 and to be listed as one of user 110c's friends), single user 110c may grant friend 110d permissions 150d to act on his/her behalf. This disclosure contemplates that permissions 150 may be friend-specific. For example, dater 110c may grant first friend 110d permissions 150d, which may include the permission to select profiles 130 in an attempt to match other users 110 with dater 110c, while dater 110c may grant second friend 110e permissions 150e, which may include the permission to suggest profiles 130 to dater 110c, but not to select profiles 130 in an attempt to match other users 110 with dater 110c.

[0061] As another example, in certain embodiments, single user 110c may grant friend 110d permission to act on his/her behalf by inviting friend 110d to join a team and/or friend group belonging to user 110c. For example, in certain embodiments, in addition to or instead of inviting friend 110d to connect with user 110c through matching tool 105 and to be listed as a friend in a friend list belonging to user 110c, user 110c may invite friend 110d to join a team and/or group belonging to user 110c. In certain embodiments, in response to user 110c inviting friend 110d to connect with user 110c through matching tool 105, matching tool 105 may automatically assign friend 110d to a team/group belonging to user 110c. In certain embodiments, joining user 110c's

team and/or group may automatically grant friend 110d permissions 150d to act on user 110c's behalf. For example, in certain embodiments, membership in user 110c's team/group may permit friend 110d to receive recommendations of profiles 130 belonging to those daters 110 who are potentially compatible with user 110c, and to select from amongst the recommended profiles. In some embodiments, membership in user 110c's team/group may permit friend 110d to act according to additional permissions 150d granted to friend 110d by user 110c. For example, as described above, dater 110c may grant friend 110d permissions 150d that may include the permission to: (1) select profiles 130 in an attempt to match other users 110 with dater 110c; (2) suggest profiles 130 to dater 110c; (3) edit profile 130c, assigned to dater 110c; (3) communicate with matches generated for dater 110c; (4) view the behavior of dater 110c while interacting with matching tool 105a; and/or (5) any other appropriate permissions that dater 110c may grant to friend 110d. In certain embodiments, permissions 150 may be group specific, such that all of the members of a user's team and/or group may be granted the same permissions 150. For example, single user 110c may grant first friend 110d permissions 150d, which are the same as permissions 150e granted to second friend 110e, in response to inviting both first friend 110d and second friend 110e to join his/her team and/or group. In some embodiments, single user 110c may create multiple teams and/or groups and assign each team and/or group a different set of permissions 150. For example, single user 110c may assign first friend 110d to a first group and second friend 110e to a second group. Single user 110c may then assign permissions 150d to the first group and permissions 150e to the second group, where permissions 150d and permissions 150e may be different from one another.

[0062] This disclosure contemplates that daters 110a and 110c may add friends 110b, 110d, and/or 110e to their friend lists, teams, and/or groups in any suitable manner. For example, in certain embodiments, in response to user 110b receiving and accepting an invite from dater 110a to register with matching tool 105, the tool may automatically add user 110b to dater 110a's friend list and/or team/group. Similarly, in response to dater 110a receiving and accepting an invite from friend 110b to register with matching tool 105, the tool may automatically add friend 110b to dater 110a's friend list and/or team/group.

[0063] As another example, in certain embodiments, dater 110a may add existing users 110b to his/her friend list, team(s), and/or group(s), where the existing users 110b have been identified by matching tool 105 as having already registered with matching tool 105. For example, in response to dater 110a granting matching tool 105 permission to access the contacts stored on device 115a of dater 110a, matching tool 105 may identify those contacts stored on device 115a who have already registered with matching tool 105. Similarly, in response to dater 110a granting matching tool 105 permission to access the friend lists stored in applications installed on device 115a, matching tool 105 may identify those friends listed in the friend lists who have already registered with matching tool 105. Matching tool 105 may identify these contacts/friends in any suitable manner. For example, matching tool 105 may identify a contact stored on device 115a as having already registered with matching tool 105 by determining that the telephone number listed for the contact is the same as a telephone

number provided by a registered user **110**. Matching tool **105** may also identify potential friends **110** for dater **110a** based on the current membership of dater **110a**'s friend list, teams(s), and/or groups. As a specific example, matching tool **105** may determine that multiple members of dater **110a**'s friend list and/or team/group are also members of dater **110c**'s friend list and/or team/group. Based on this information, matching tool **105** may determine that a high probability exists that dater **110c** is a friend or acquaintance of dater **110a**. Accordingly, matching tool **105** may suggest to dater **110a** that he/she add dater **110c** to his/her friend list and/or team/group. As another example, in certain embodiments, dater **110a** may add existing users **110b** to his/her friend list and/or team/group by searching through a list of users **110** registered with matching tool **105** and inviting those users **110** that he/she recognizes and/or wishes to add to his/her friend list and/or team/group. As a further example, in certain embodiments, dater **110a** may add existing users **110b** to his/her team/group by viewing the membership lists of the other teams/groups to which dater **110a** may belong (e.g., the teams/groups in which dater **110a** is acting as a friend for another dater) and/or by viewing the friend lists of those users who belong to dater **110a**'s friend list (e.g., viewing the friends of dater **110a**'s friends).

[0064] This disclosure contemplates that a given dater **110a** may form any number of teams and/or groups for him/herself. For example, dater **110a** may place his/her high school friends in a first team/group and his/her college friends in a second team/group. Similarly, a given friend **110b** may be placed in any number of teams/group and/or be granted permission to act on behalf of any number of daters **110**. For example, both dater **110a** and dater **110c** may place friend **110b** in each their teams/groups and/or grant friend **110b** permission to act on each of their behalf. Friend **110b** may then choose between acting on behalf of dater **110a** or acting on behalf of dater **110c**, when interacting with matching tool **105**. This disclosure contemplates that in addition to being a friend of both dater **110a** and dater **110c**, user **110b** may also be a dater him/herself. Accordingly, user **110b** may choose between acting on behalf of dater **110a**, dater **110c**, or him/herself, when interacting with matching tool **105**. During a single online dating session, user **110b** may switch between acting on behalf of dater **110a**, dater **110c**, and him/herself. Switching between acting of behalf of dater **110a**, dater **110c**, or user **110b**, him/herself, may consist simply of selecting one of dater **110a**, dater **110c**, and user **110b**, him/herself, from a drop-down menu displayed by matching tool **105** on device **115b**.

[0065] After a user **110** registers with matching tool **105** as either "single" or "in a relationship," matching tool **105** may transmit request **185** to user **110** seeking personal information from user **110**. FIG. 2B illustrates the process by which profile generator **160** of matching tool **105** may request personal information from users **110**, receive personal information from users **110**, and generate profiles **130** using this personal information.

[0066] In response to receiving an indication **220** from dater **110a**, indicating that dater **110a** would like to register as "single" with matching tool **105**, profile generator **160** may send request **225** to dater **110a**, seeking personal information from dater **110a**. This disclosure contemplates that request **225** may seek any personal information from dater **110a** suitable to generate a profile **130a** for dater **110a** and/or to identify dater **110a** in the online dating system

generated by matching tool **105**. For example, the personal information sought by request **225** may include dater **110a**'s: (1) name; (2) birthdate; (3) gender; (4) height; (5) political views; (6) physical activity level; (7) religion; (8) occupations; and/or (9) astrological sign. The personal information sought by request **225** may also include whether or not dater **110a** has any children or pets, whether or not dater **110a** smokes or drinks alcohol, and/or any other personal information suitable to identify dater **110a** and/or facilitate matching between dater **110a** and other daters **110**. In certain embodiments, request **225** may also seek one or more photos of dater **110a**. In some embodiments, request **225** may additionally ask dater **110a** to describe him/herself, by providing one or more free-form descriptions of him/herself. For example, request **225** may ask dater **110a** to describe him/herself by using (1) text only; (2) emojis only; (3) GIFs only; and/or (4) any combination of text, emojis, and/or GIFs. In response to receiving request **225**, dater **110a** may transmit personal information **230** to matching tool **105** for use by profile generator **160**.

[0067] In certain embodiments, profile generator **160** may use request **225** to discover what dater **110a** may be looking for in a potential match. For example, request **225** may ask dater **110a** to specify his/her preference in gender and age range of a potential match. As another example, request **225** may also ask dater **110a** to specify a distance within which dater **110a** would prefer a potential match to be located. As a further example, request **225** may ask dater **110a** to indicate how important certain factors are when looking for a match. In response to receiving such request **225**, dater **110a** may provide information **230** indicating the relative importance that he/she places on such factors. For example, information **230** may indicate that dater **110a** places a high importance on the religion of any potential matches and a low importance on the political views of any potential matches.

[0068] As illustrated in FIG. 2B, in response to receiving information **230** from dater **110a**, profile generator may use information **230** to generate profile **130a**, assigned to dater **110a**. For example, profile generator **160** may store the responses provided by dater **110a** to each request **225** for information in profile **130a**. Profile generator **160** may also store dater **110a**'s friend list and/or one or more lists of the members of dater **110a**'s team(s)/group(s), as well as any teams/groups to which dater **110a** belongs in profile **130a**. For example, in certain embodiments, profile **130a** may indicate that friend **110b** belongs to dater **110a**'s team/group and that dater **110a** is a member of dater **110c**'s team/group. As another example, in certain embodiments, profile **130a** may indicate that friend **110b** is a friend of dater **110a**.

[0069] In certain embodiments, profile generator **160** may generate the same type of profile **130** for users **110b** who register with matching tool **105** as "in a relationship" as users **110a** who register as "single." For example, in certain embodiments, in response to receiving an indication **235** from friend **110b**, indicating that friend **110b** would like to register as "in a relationship" with matching tool **105**, profile generator **160** may send request **240** to friend **110b**, seeking the same types of personal information from friend **110b** as request **225** sought from dater **110a**. On the other hand, in some embodiments, profile generator **160** may generate less detailed profiles **130** for users **110b** who register with matching tool **105** as "in a relationship," as compared with users **110a** who register with matching tool **105** as "single."

For example, in response to receiving indication **235** from friend **110b** that friend **110b** would like to register as “in a relationship,” profile generator **160** may send request **240** to friend **110b**, seeking basic personal information from friend **110b**. For example, request **240** may ask friend **110b** for his/her: (1) name; (2) birthdate; (3) geographical location; (4) telephone number; and/or (5) any other personal information suitable to identify friend **110b** to other users **110**. Profile generator **160** may seek more detailed personal information from dater **110a** as compared with friend **110b**, because matching tool **105** may be configured to generate recommendations of other, potentially compatible daters **110** for dater **110a**, based at least in part on the information included in profile **130a** of dater **110a**. On the other hand, the information included in profile **130b** of friend **110b** may simply be used to help dater **110a** identify friend **110b** as an individual that dater **110a** knows outside of the online dating experience generated by matching tool **105** and that dater **110a** would like to invite to join his/her friend list and/or team/group.

[0070] In certain embodiments, profile generator **160** may add information to profile **130b**, belonging to friend **110b**, in response to the activities performed by friend **110b** on behalf of dater **110a**. For example, profile generator **160** may add information to profile **130b** to indicate (1) the number of times that friend **110b** has selected a profile on behalf of dater **110a**; (2) the number of matches that have been generated for dater **110a** as a result of friend **110b**’s selections; (3) the rate at which friend **110b** selects profiles for dater **110a** (e.g., the number of selections per day); (4) how selective friend **110b** is in choosing profiles (e.g., friend **110b** may be assigned a high selectivity factor if friend **110b** selects only a small portion of the profiles **130** presented to him/her, or a low selectivity factor if friend **110b** selects a large portion of the profiles presented to him/her; (5) the number of positive interactions experienced by dater **110a** based on selections made by friends **110b**, which may be determined automatically based on data captured by matching tool **105** or manually entered by dater **110a**; and/or (6) any other information relating to friend **110b**’s activities while interacting with matching tool **105**. For example, profile generator **160** may also add badges to profile **130b**, to indicate achievements obtained by friend **110b**. For example, profile generator **160** may add a “super-setter-upper” badge to profile **130b** to indicate that the number of matches that friend **110b** has generated for dater **110a** has exceeded a given threshold.

[0071] Profile generator **160** may be a software module stored in memory **140** and executed by processor **135**. An example algorithm for profile generator **160** is as follows: (1) receive indication **220** that dater **110a** seeks to register as “single” with matching tool **105**; (2) transmit request **225** to dater **110a**, asking for detailed personal information from dater **110a**; (3) receive detailed personal information **230** from dater **110a**; (4) in response to receiving detailed personal information **230** from dater **110a**, generate profile **130a**, based on detailed personal information **230**; (5) store profile **130a** in database **125**; (6) receive indication **235** that friend **110b** seeks to register as “in a relationship” with matching tool **105**; (7) transmit request **240** to friend **110b**, asking for basic personal information from friend **110b**; (8) receive basic personal information **245** from friend **110b**; (9) in response to receiving basic personal information **245** from friend **110b**, generate profile **130b**, based on basic personal

information **245**; and (10) store profile **130b** in database **125**. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for profile generator **160**, this disclosure contemplates that profile generator **160** may use any algorithm operable to receive information from users **110** and generate profiles **130** based on such information. For example, the algorithm used by profile generator **160** may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by profile generator **160** may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0072] While illustrated in FIG. 2B as dater **110a** interacting with profile generator **160** to generate profile **130a** for him/herself and friend **110b** similarly interacting with profile generator **160** to generate profile **130b** for him/herself, in certain embodiments, friend **110b** may be able to interact with profile generator **160** to generate profile **130a** for dater **110a**. For example, in certain embodiments, dater **110a** may grant friend **110b** permission to edit and/or complete his/her profile **130a**. In some embodiments, dater **110a** may grant friend **110b** permission to suggest edits to dater **110a**’s profile **130a**. Dater **110a** may then choose whether or not to accept the suggested edits. As another example, after registering as “in a relationship” with matching tool **105**, friend **110b** may be permitted to generate a profile **130** for one or more of his/her single friends who have not yet registered with matching tool **105**. In this manner, friend **110b** may be able to receive recommendations and select potential matches for his/her single friend before the single friend has ever interacted with matching tool **105**. This may be desirable as it may enable friend **110b** to participate in the online dating experience even if none of his/her single friends have completed the registration process at the time friend **110b** registers with the system. This may also be desirable as the single friend for whom friend **110b** has generated a profile may be more inclined to register with matching tool **105** if he/she knows that he/she has already been matched with one or more daters **110a** and/or **110c** in the system, before he/she has even signed up.

[0073] In certain embodiments, for privacy reasons, friend **110b** may only be permitted by matching tool **105** to generate a profile **130** for one of his/her single friends who have not yet registered with matching tool **105** if friend **110b** and/or matching tool **105** first obtains the permission of the single friend(s). For example, in certain embodiments, in response to friend **110b** generating profile **130a** for his/her single friend, matching tool **105** may send a message (e.g., an email or SMS message) to the single friend requesting that the single friend approve the profile. If the single friend declines to approve profile **130a**, the profile may not be viewable, searchable, or selectable by any users **110** of matching tool **105**.

[0074] In certain embodiments, friend **110b** may not be required to register with matching tool **105** or to provide any profile information to matching tool **105** prior to interacting with matching tool **105**. For example, in certain embodiments, dater **110a** may permit friend **110b** to select profiles **130** on behalf of dater **110a** by providing friend **110b** access to the online dating system generated by matching tool **105** through a rich media component embedded in an email and/or SMS message. This rich media component may provide friend **110b** with a singular instance of access to matching tool **105**, where friend **110b** is granted access to

the tool as dater **110a** (e.g., matching tool **105** may attribute any actions performed by friend **110b** to dater **110a**). Enabling friend **110b** to participate in the online-matching experience of dater **110a** without registering with matching tool **105** or providing any profile information to matching tool **105** may be desirable for those individuals who are in a relationship and do not want to download and/or register with an online dating tool out of fear of the appearance of impropriety.

[0075] In certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may enable users **110** to share profile information onto one or more social media networks. As an example, matching tool **105** may enable dater **110a** to share his/her profile picture onto a social media network. Dater **110a** may wish to share his/her profile picture onto a social media network in order to obtain feedback from his/her connections on the social media network, and/or to encourage his/her connections on the social media network to join matching tool **105** and to become members of dater **110a**'s friend list and/or team/group. As another example, matching tool **105** may enable friend **110b** of dater **110a** to share profile information belonging to dater **110a** onto one or more social media networks. For example, friend **110b** may share a profile picture belonging to dater **110a** onto a social media network, to advertise that dater **110a** is seeking a relationship and to encourage members of the social media network to join matching tool **105** to attempt to match with dater **110a**. In certain embodiments, friend **110b** may only be permitted to share profile information belonging to dater **110a** onto social media networks if dater **110a** has granted friend **110b** the permission to do so (e.g., dater **110a** has set permissions **150b** for friend **110b** to enable friend **110b** to share dater **110a**'s profile information).

[0076] In certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may enable users **110** to publish and/or share a link to their profiles **130** and/or profiles **130** of their friends. For example, matching tool **105** may enable dater **110a** to publish and/or share a link to his/her profile **130a** on one or more social networks, on a website, in an email, in an SMS message, or in any other suitable manner. As another example, matching tool **105** may enable friend **110b** of dater **110a** to publish and/or share a link to dater **110a**'s profile on one or more social networks, on a website, in an email, in an SMS message, or in any other suitable manner.

[0077] In certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may charge a subscription fee to users **110**. This subscription fee may be limited to those users who register as "single" with matching tool **105**, and become daters in the system, or the fee may be charged to both users who register as "single" as well as users who register as "in a relationship" with matching tool **105**.

[0078] In certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may enable one or more of the members of a dater's friend list and/or team/group to pay for his/her subscription fee. As an example, in certain embodiments, an interactive option may exist on a dater's profile **130**, inviting the dater's friends to pay all or part of the dater's subscription costs. For example, the option may permit a friend to pay for the dater's subscription costs for a set period of time (e.g., two months), or may permit a friend to pay for a portion of the dater's recurring subscription charge (e.g., \$5 dollars out of the total subscription charge). In certain embodiments, the option for a friend to pay for all or part of the dater's subscription costs may exist on all dater profiles **130**. In other embodiments, a

dater **110** may choose to add the option to his/her profile **130**. In some embodiments, matching tool **105** may additionally enable a dater **110** to solicit subscription contributions from his/her friends by adding a personalized message to his/her profile **130**, requesting contributions, and/or by sending messages to his/her team/group members requesting contributions. In certain embodiments, if a dater **110** lapses in one or more of his subscription payments, matching tool **105** may solicit the lapsed payments from dater **110**'s friends. For example, matching tool **105** may send a message to dater **110**'s friends asking the friends to "chip in and help dater **110** continue his search for love," or any other suitable request for monetary contributions from dater **110**'s friends.

[0079] In certain embodiments, in addition to the payment of a subscription fee, matching tool **105** may enable dater **110** and/or dater **110**'s friends to pay for any number of a-la-carte features. For example, user **110** may purchase a "powerup" to boost the visibility of his/her profile **130** or of a profile **130** belonging to one of his/her friends. As another example, by default, user **110a**'s connections (e.g., list of friends and/or team/group members) may not be visible to another user **110d**, who is not connected with user **110a**, without payment of a fee. User **110d** may wish to pay such a fee to view user **110a**'s connections in order to help the user evaluate user **110a** when determining whether or not to attempt to match with user **110a** or to select user **110a** on behalf of one of user **110d**'s friends.

[0080] While FIG. 2B illustrates profile generator **160** generating profiles **130** for dater **110a** and friend **110b**, this disclosure contemplates that profile generator **160** may generate profiles **130** for any number of users **110**. Furthermore, this disclosure contemplates that modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to profile generator **160** without departing from the scope of the invention. For example, this disclosure contemplates that some or all of the operations described above as being performed by profile generator **160**, may be performed by other components of matching tool **105**. Such components may be integrated or separated. Furthermore, the operations may be performed using any suitable logic comprising software, hardware, and/or other logic.

[0081] In certain embodiments, once dater **110a** has registered with matching tool **105**, recommendation engine **165** may generate recommendations of other potentially compatible daters **110** for dater **110a**. FIGS. 3A through 3C illustrate examples of the behavior of recommendation engine **165** of matching tool **105**, in response to transmitting recommendations of profiles **130** and receiving profile selections from dater **110a** and/or one or more of friends **110b** and **110f** of dater **110a**. FIG. 3A illustrates the behavior of recommendation engine **165** when presenting profile recommendations **310** for dater **110a** to dater **110a**, and FIGS. 3B and 3C illustrate examples of the behavior of recommendation engine **165** when presenting profile recommendations **310** for dater **110a** to friends of dater **110a**.

[0082] As illustrated, FIGS. 3A through 3C represent scenarios that may occur at a given point in time at which recommendation algorithm **145** is configured to generate first series of profile recommendations **310** for dater **110a**. The scenario presented in FIG. 3A may occur if, in response to transmitting first series of profile recommendations **310**, recommendation engine **165** receives selection **315a** from dater **110a**, prior to receiving any selections **315b** and/or **315c** from friends **110b** and/or **110f** of dater **110a**. The

scenario presented in FIG. 3B may occur if, in response to response to transmitting first series of profile recommendations 310, recommendation engine 165 receives selection 315b from first friend 110b, prior to receiving any selections 315a from dater 110a or any selections 315c from second friend 110f. The scenario presented in FIG. 3C may occur if, in response to transmitting first series of profile recommendations 310, recommendation engine 165 receives selection 315b from first friend 110b and selection 351c from second friend 110f, prior to receiving any selections 315a from dater 110a.

[0083] As mentioned above, FIG. 3A illustrates an example operation of recommendation engine 165 in response to receiving request 305a from dater 110a seeking recommendations of profiles 130, belonging to other daters 110 who are potentially compatible with dater 110a. As illustrated in FIG. 3A, in response to receiving request 305a, recommendation engine 165 uses recommendation algorithm 145 to generate a set of profile recommendations for dater 110a. For example, recommendation engine 165 may generate first series of profile recommendations 310. First series of profile recommendations 310 may include any number of profiles 130, belonging to daters 110 that recommendation engine 165 has determined may potentially be compatible with dater 110a. For example, in certain embodiments, first series of profile recommendations 310 may include an ordered set of dater profiles, {130g, 130h, 130i, 130j, 130k}, belonging, respectively, to daters 110g, 110h, 110i, 110j, and 110k, and ordered according to a predicted compatibility between each dater and dater 110a (e.g., the fact that profile 130g appears earlier in series 310 than profile 130h may indicate that matching algorithm 145 has predicted that dater 110a is likely more compatible with dater 110g than with dater 110h).

[0084] In response to receiving first series of profile recommendations 310, dater 110a may transmit one or more selections 315a from first series of profile recommendations 310, identifying profiles 130 belonging to daters 110 with whom dater 110a would like to be matched. For example, after viewing profiles 130g, 130h, 130i, 130j, and 130k, dater 110a may react favorably to the information contained in profile 130h, and, therefore, may wish to be matched with and/or communicate with dater 110h. Accordingly, dater 110a may transmit a selection 315a of profile 130h to matching tool 105. This disclosure contemplates that dater 110a may transmit selection 315a to matching tool 105 in any suitable manner. For example, in certain embodiments, dater 110a may transmit selection 315a to matching tool 105 by interacting with a button displayed by matching tool 105 on a display of device 115a, belonging to dater 110a. As another example, in certain embodiments, dater 110a may transmit selection 315a to matching tool 105 by gesturing on the display of device 115a.

[0085] In response to receiving selection 315a, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to use selection 315a to update the profile recommendations that recommendation engine 165 may transmit to dater 110a in the future. For example, in response to receiving selection 315a, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to transmit second series of profile recommendations 320a to dater 110a, where second series of profile recommendations 320a is different from first series of profile recommendations 310. As an example, in certain embodiments, second series of profile recommendations 320a will not include those pro-

files 130 selected by dater 110a, through selection 315a. As another example, in certain embodiments, second series of profile recommendations 320a will not include those profiles 130 from first series of profile recommendations 310 for which dater 110a may have indicated a negative preference. As a further example, in certain embodiments, second series of profile recommendations 320a may include new profiles 130, not present in first series of profile recommendations 310. Second series of profile recommendations 320a may also include a reordering of profiles 130, previously presented in first series of profile recommendations 310. This disclosure contemplates that the differences between first series of profile recommendations 310 and second series of profile recommendations 320a may arise as a result of selection 315a, made by dater 110a.

[0086] This disclosure contemplates that recommendation algorithm 145 may be any algorithm configured to generate recommendations of profiles 130 belonging to other daters 110 who are potentially compatible with dater 110a. As an example, in certain embodiments, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to generate profile recommendations 310 and 320a based at least in part on a comparison between features of profile 130a, belonging to dater 110a, and the features of profiles 130 belonging to other daters 110. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to determine that dater 110a and dater 110g are likely compatible based at least in part on a high degree of similarity between profile information 230 provided by dater 110a and the profile information provided by dater 110g. Such profile information may, for example, indicate that both dater 110a and dater 110g are non-smokers who own dogs and enjoy hiking.

[0087] As another example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to generate profile recommendations 320a based at least in part on previous selections 315a made by dater 110a. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to learn from previous selections 315a, to identify those profile features that dater 110a finds desirable in potential matches. As a specific example, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine that dater 110a tends to select profiles 130 belonging to daters 130 that indicate that the daters 130 are more than six feet tall, non-religious, and like cats. Accordingly, recommendation algorithm 145 may place a greater importance on profiles 130 belonging to other daters 130 who similarly indicate through their profiles 130 that they are more than six feet tall, non-religious, and like cats, when determining daters 110 who are potentially compatible with dater 110a. As another example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to analyze the photos provided in the profiles previously selected by dater 110a, to determine the physical qualities of other daters 110 that dater 110a finds most appealing. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine that dater 110a tends to select profiles 130 that include pictures of daters with black hair who are playing the guitar. Accordingly, recommendation algorithm 145 may place a greater importance on profiles 130 that include photos of daters with black hair who are playing the guitar, as compared with other profiles 130, when determining daters 110 who are potentially compatible with dater 110a.

[0088] As another example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to generate recommendations 320a based at least in part on previous selections 315a made by dater 110a as well as previous selections made by other

daters 110. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to generate recommended profiles 320a by identifying other daters 110 with similar matching tastes to dater 110a. For instance, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine that selections 315a made by dater 110a tend to be similar to the selections made by a different dater 110m. Therefore, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine that dater 110a and dater 110m have similar tastes in profiles 130. Accordingly, if dater 110m selects a profile 130 that dater 110a has not yet seen, recommendation algorithm 145 may present such profile to dater 110a under the assumption that a high probability exists that dater 110a will also select the profile.

[0089] As a further example, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to generate profile recommendations 320a based at least in part on the relative popularity of profile 130a, belonging to dater 110a, as compared with the popularity of other profiles 130, belonging to other daters 110. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may group users 110 based on the number of times their profiles 130 have been selected by other users. This number may correspond to a relative attractiveness score (e.g., a profile 130 selected a large number of times may be assigned a higher attractiveness score than a profile 130 selected a smaller number of times). Recommendation algorithm 145 may then generate profile recommendations 310 and 320a by recommending to dater 110a those profiles 130 that belong to the same attractiveness grouping as profile 110a, belonging to dater 110a, under the assumption that people are more likely to match with people of similar attractiveness.

[0090] Recommendation engine 165 may be configured to transmit recommendations 310 not only to dater 110a, but also to friends of dater 110a, for selection therefrom. FIG. 3B illustrates an example of the behavior of recommendation engine 165 when presenting profile recommendations 310 for dater 110a to friend 110b of dater 110a.

[0091] As illustrated in FIG. 3B, in response to receiving request 305b from first friend 110b, asking for recommendations of profiles 130 belonging to other daters 110 who are potentially compatible with dater 110a, recommendation engine 165 uses recommendation algorithm 145 to generate first series of profile recommendations 310. This disclosure contemplates that recommendation engine 165 may transmit the same first series of profile recommendations 310 to friend 110b as recommendation engine 165 would transmit to dater 110a. As described above, first series of profile recommendations 310 may include an ordered set of dater profiles, {130g, 130h, 130i, 130j, 130k}, belonging, respectively, to daters 110g, 110h, 110i, 110j, and 110k, and ordered according to a predicted compatibility between each dater and dater 110a (e.g., recommendation engine 165 may present friend 110b with recommendations of those daters 110 that recommendation algorithm 145 has determined are most likely compatible with dater 110a, prior to presenting recommendations of other daters 110 that recommendation algorithm 145 has determined may be less compatible with dater 110a).

[0092] In response to receiving first series of profile recommendations 310, first friend 110b may transmit one or more selections 315b from first series of profile recommendations 310, identifying profiles 130 belonging to daters 110 with whom first friend 110b would like to see dater 110a matched. For example, after viewing profiles 130g, 130h,

130i, 130j, and 130k, first friend 110b may believe that dater 110a and dater 110i would make a good match. Accordingly, dater 110a may transmit a selection 315b of profile 130i to matching tool 105.

[0093] In response to receiving selection 315b from friend 110b, the behavior of recommendation algorithm 145 may depend on the permissions dater 110a has granted to friend 110b. As an example, permissions 150b may indicate that dater 110a has granted first friend 110b the permission to select profiles 130 to present as suggestions to dater 110a, but not to select profiles 130 as potential matches for dater 110a. Accordingly, in response to receiving selection 315b, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to reorder first series of profile recommendations 310 to form third series of profile recommendations 320b, placing profile(s) 130, associated with selection 315b, earlier in third series of profile recommendations 320b than in first series of profile recommendations 310. For example, if first friend 110b transmits a selection 315b of profile 130i to recommendation engine 165, recommendation algorithm 145 may transmit a third series of profile recommendations 320b to dater 110b that includes the same dater profiles 130 as first series of profile recommendations 310 (namely, profiles 130g, 130h, 130i, 130j, and 130k), but ordered to place profile 130i at the beginning of the series (e.g., the next time dater 110a requests that recommendation engine 165 transmit profile recommendations to dater 110a, recommendation engine 165 may present dater 110a with those profiles 130 suggested to dater 110a by friend 110b, prior to presenting other profiles 130 not suggested to dater 110a).

[0094] In certain embodiments, in response to receiving selection 315b from friend 110b, recommendation engine 165 may be configured to transmit a third series of profile recommendations 320b to dater 110b that includes an indication on profile 130, chosen by friend 110b as selection 315b, indicating that friend 110b has suggested profile 130 to dater 110a. For example, recommendation engine 165 may be configured to include a statement on the suggested profile 130 such as “friend 110b thinks that the two of you would make a great match,” or any similar phrase indicating that friend 110b has suggested profile 130 to dater 110a. Where more than one friend 110b has suggested a given profile 130 to dater 110a, recommendation engine 165 may be configured to include an indication on the profile of the number of friends who have recommended the profile.

[0095] In some embodiments, permissions 150b may indicate that dater 110a has granted first friend 110b the permission to select profiles 130 as potential matches for dater 110a. Accordingly, in response to receiving selection 315b, recommendation engine 145 may be configured to use selection 315b to update the profile recommendations generated for dater 110a, in a similar manner as described above, in the scenario of FIG. 3A, in which recommendation engine received selection 315a from dater 110a. For example, in response to receiving selection 315b, recommendation algorithm 145 may be configured to transmit a third series of profile recommendations 320b to dater 110a, where third series of profile recommendations 320b is different from first series of profile recommendations 310. As an example, in certain embodiments, third series of profile recommendations 320b will not include those profiles 130 selected by friend 110b through selection 315b. As another example, in certain embodiments, third series of profile recommendations 320b will not include those pro-

files **130** from first series of profile recommendations **310** for which friend **110b** may have indicated a negative preference. Alternatively, in some embodiments, third series of profile recommendations **320b** may continue to include those profiles **130** from first series of profile recommendations **310** for which friend **110b** may have indicated a negative preference, to provide dater **110a**, him/herself, an opportunity to evaluate the profiles. As a further example, in certain embodiments, third series of profile recommendations **320b** may include new profiles **130**, not present in first series of profile recommendations **310**. Third series of profile recommendations **320b** may additionally include a reordering of profiles **130**, previously presented in first series of profile recommendations **310**.

[0096] This disclosure contemplates that third series of profile recommendations **320b** may be different from second series of profile recommendations **320a**. This difference may arise from the fact that friend **110b** may have provided different selections **315b** to recommendation engine than dater **110a**, him/herself would have provided. For example, as described above, first friend **110b** may have selected profile **130i**, whereas dater **110a** would have selected profile **130h**. However, even if first friend **110b** selected the same profile(s) **130** as dater **110a**, him/herself would have selected, in certain embodiments, third series of profile recommendations **320b** may nevertheless still be different from second series of profile recommendations **320a**. This difference may arise as a result of the fact that recommendation algorithm **145** may apply different weights to the selections **315a** and **315b** made by dater **110a** and friend **110b**, respectively. For example, matching tool **105** may assign a first weight **155a** to selections **315a** made by dater **110a** and a second weight **155b** to selections **315b** made by friend **110b**, on behalf of dater **110a**. Recommendation algorithm **145** may then use these weights **155** when generating new recommendations for dater **110a** (e.g., second series of profile recommendations **320a** and third series of profile recommendations **320b**). For example, if weight **155a**, assigned to dater **110a**, is significantly larger than weight **155b**, assigned to friend **110b**, then selections **315a** made by dater **110a** may have a larger impact on the resulting profile recommendations **320a** generated by recommendation algorithm **145** than the impact made by selections **315b** on resulting profile recommendations **320b**.

[0097] Matching tool **105** may determine weights **155** in any suitable manner. For example, in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign higher weights **155a** and **155c** to daters **110a** and **110c**, as compared to friends **110b**, **110d**, **110e**, and **110f**, given that the daters are the ones that must ultimately approve of a match in order to form a successful dating relationship. As another example, in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based on the relative selectivity of users **110**. For example, matching tool **105** may assign a low weight **155** to a user who selects the majority of profiles **130** presented to him/her and a higher weight **155** to a user who selects only a portion of the profiles **130** presented to him/her. As another example, in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based on the success of users **110** in generating matches for a given dater **110a**. For example, matching tool **105** may assign a higher weight **155b** to a friend **110b** whose selections **315b** tend to lead to matches (as described below, in the discussion of FIGS. 4A through 4C) more often than selections **315a**, received from dater **110a**. As a further example,

in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based not simply on the success of users **110** in generating matches for a given dater **110a**, but also on the success of users **110** in generating successful matches for dater **110a**. For example, in certain embodiments matching tool **105** may be configured to determine whether or not dater **110a** met with his/her matches, and to solicit feedback from dater **110a** and/or his/her matches to determine if the matches were successful. As a specific example, matching tool **105** may determine that dater **110a** and dater **110c** likely met in person, by monitoring a conversation between dater **110a** and dater **110c**. For instance, the conversation may indicate that dater **110a** and dater **110c** exchanged phone numbers and/or exchanged certain keywords and/or phrases indicative of users planning to meet with one another. In response to determining that dater **110a** and dater **110c** likely met in person, matching tool **105** may transmit surveys to dater **110a** and dater **110c**, asking the daters to evaluate one another. Matching tool **105** may assign a higher weight **155b** to a friend **110b** whose selections **315b** tend to lead to successful matches (as determined based on the survey responses provided by dater **110a** and his/her matches) more often than selections **315a**, received from dater **110a**.

[0098] FIG. 3C illustrates an example of the behavior of recommendation engine **165** when receiving selections **315** from multiple friends **110** of dater **110a**. While this disclosure contemplates that recommendation engine **165** may receive selections **315** from any number of friends **110**, for simplicity, FIG. 3C presents a situation in which recommendation engine **165** receives selection **315b** from friend **110b** and selection **315c** from friend **110f**.

[0099] Similar to the situation described above, in the discussion of FIG. 3B, the behavior of recommendation algorithm **145** in response to receiving selection **315b** from friend **110b** and selection **315c** from friend **110f**, the behavior of recommendation algorithm **145** may depend on the permissions dater **110a** has granted to friend **110b** and friend **110f**. As an example, permissions **150b** and **150f** may indicate that dater **110a** has granted both first friend **110b** and second friend **110f** permission to select profiles **130** to present as suggestions to dater **110a**, but not to select profiles **130** as potential matches for dater **110a**. Accordingly, in response to transmitting first series of profile recommendations **310** to both first friend **110b** and second friend **110f**, recommendation engine **165** may receive profile suggestions (in the form of selections **315**) from both first friend **110b** and second friend **110f**. In certain embodiments, recommendation engine may generate a resulting series of profile recommendations **320c** to transmit to dater **110a** by placing an indication on each profile **130** selected by first friend **110b** and/or second friend **110f**, indicating that first friend **110b** and/or second friend **110f** has suggested the profile for dater **110a**. In some embodiments, recommendation engine may generate a resulting series of profile recommendations **320c** to transmit to dater **110a** by reordering first series of profile recommendations **310** to place a suggested profile **130** at the beginning of the series, each time recommendation engine receives a selection **315** from first friend **110b** or second friend **110f**, suggesting a profile. For example, if recommendation engine **165** first receives selection **315b** of profile **130k** from first friend **110b**, recommendation engine **165** may reorder first series of profile recommendations **310** from {**130g**, **130h**, **130i**, **130j**, **130k**} to {**130k**, **130g**, **130h**, **130i**, **130j**}. If recommendation engine **165** next receives

selection **315c** of profile **130j** from second friend **110b**, recommendation engine **165** may further reorder first series of profile recommendations to **{130j, 130k, 130g, 130h, 130i}**. Recommendation engine **165** may then transmit this reordered series of profile recommendations to dater **110a** as fourth series of profile recommendations **320c**.

[0100] In certain embodiments in which recommendation engine **165** uses suggestions **315b** and **315c** to generate a reordered series of profile recommendations **320c** to transmit to dater **110a**, recommendation engine **165** may reorder first series of profile recommendations **310** according to weights **155b** and **155f** assigned to friends **110b** and **110f**, respectively (and accordingly, assigned to the selections **315b** and **315c** received from friends **110b** and **110f**). In such embodiments, weights **155** may be used to determine the relative movement prescribed by recommendation engine **165** to a profile specified by selection **315**, when reordering the profiles presented in first series of profile recommendations **310**, to generate profile recommendations **320c**. For example, if a higher weight **155b** is assigned to selection **315b** of profile **130k** than weight **155c**, assigned to selection **315c** of profile **130j**, recommendation engine **165** may reorder first series of profile recommendations **310** to place profile **130k** earlier in the resulting series than profile **130j** (e.g., recommendation engine **165** may assign a large movement to profile **130k** and a smaller movement to profile **130j**). For example, recommendation engine **165** may reorder first series of profiles recommendations **310** from **{130g, 130h, 130i, 130j, 130k}** to **{130k, 130g, 130h, 130j, 130i}**, and transmit this reordered series of profile recommendations to dater **110a** as fourth series of profile recommendations **320c**. In this manner, recommendation engine **165** may present dater **110a** with those profiles **130** suggested by friend **110b** prior to presenting dater **110a** with those profiles **130** suggested by friend **110f**. In certain embodiments, the weights **155** assigned to friends **110b** and **110f** may correspond directly with the size of the movement that recommendation engine **165** may give to the profiles **130** selected by friends **110b** and **110f**, when reordering first series of profile recommendations **310**. For example, a value of 1 for weight **155b** may indicate that profiles **130** suggested for dater **110a** by first friend **110b** are to be moved up one location in the reordered series of profile recommendations **320c** to be sent to dater **110a**, as compared with their locations in first series of profile recommendations **310**. Similarly, a value of 5 for weight **155f** may indicate that the profiles **130** suggested for dater **110a** by second friend **110f** are to be moved up five locations in the reordered series of profile recommendations **320c**, as compared with their locations in first series of profile recommendations **310**.

[0101] Matching tool **105** may determine weights **155** in any suitable manner. As an example, in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based on the relative selectivity of friends **110b** and **110f**. For example, matching tool **105** may assign a low weight **155b** to friend **110b** if friend **110b** tends to select the majority of profiles **130** presented to him/her and a higher weight **155f** to friend **110f** if friend **110f** tends to select a smaller portion of the profiles **130** presented to him/her. As another example, in certain embodiments matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based on the relative success of the suggestions made by friend **110b** as compared with friend **110f**. For example, if dater **110a** tends to select a majority of the suggestions made by friend **110b**, matching tool **105** may

assign a high weight **155b** to friend **110b**. On the other hand, if dater **110a** tends to reject a majority of the suggestions made by friend **110f**, matching tool **105** may assign a low weight **155f** to friend **110f**. As a further example, in certain embodiments, matching tool **105** may assign weights **155** based not simply on the success of users **110** in generating matches for a given dater **110a**, but also on the success of users **110** in generating successful matches for dater **110a**. For example, in certain embodiments matching tool **105** may be configured to determine whether or not dater **110a** met with his/her matches, and to solicit feedback from dater **110a** and/or his/her matches to determine if the matches were successful. As a specific example, matching tool **105** may determine that dater **110a** and dater **110c** likely met in person, by monitoring a conversation between dater **110a** and dater **110c**. For instance, the conversation may indicate that dater **110a** and dater **110c** exchanged phone numbers and/or exchanged certain keywords and/or phrases indicative of users planning to meet with one another. In response to determining that dater **110a** and dater **110c** likely met in person, matching tool **105** may transmit surveys to dater **110a** and dater **110c**, asking the daters to evaluate one another. Matching tool **105** may assign a higher weight **155b** to a friend **110b** whose selections **315b** tend to lead to successful matches (as determined based on the survey responses provided by dater **110a** and his/her matches) more often than selections **315c**, received from friend **110f**.

[0102] In certain embodiments, rather than generating a reordered series of profile recommendations in response to receiving suggestions from friends **110b** and/or **110f**, matching tool **105** may use the suggestions to generate a leaderboard of the suggested profiles **130**. For example, matching tool **105** may generate a leaderboard that lists the ten profiles **130** that have obtained the greatest number of suggestions from dater **110a**'s friends. Generating such a leaderboard may be desirable in certain embodiments in which dater **110a** is a famous individual, with a very large list of friends and/or team/group.

[0103] In some embodiments, permissions **150b** and **150f** may indicate that dater **110a** has granted both first friend **110b** and second friend **110f** permission to select profiles **130** as potential matches for dater **110a**. In such embodiments, in response to receiving selections **315b** and **315c**, recommendation engine **145** may be configured to use both selections **315b** and **315c** to update the profile recommendations generated for dater **110a**, in a similar manner as described above, in the scenario of FIG. 3B, in which recommendation engine received selection **315b** from friend **110b**. For example, in response to receiving selections **315b** and **315c**, recommendation algorithm **145** may be configured to transmit fourth series of profile recommendations **320c** to dater **110a**, where fourth series of profile recommendations **320c** is different from first series of profile recommendations **310**. As an example, in certain embodiments, fourth series of profile recommendations **320c** will not include those profiles **130** selected by friend **110b** through selection **315b** and by friend **110f** through selection **315c**.

[0104] As another example, in certain embodiments, fourth series of profile recommendations **320c** will not include those profiles **130** from first series of profile recommendations **310** for which friend **110b** and/or friend **110f** may have indicated a negative preference. Alternatively, in some embodiments, fourth series of profile recommenda-

tions 320c may continue to include those profiles 130 from first series of profile recommendations 310 for which friend 110b and/or friend 110f may have indicated a negative preference, to provide dater 110a, him/herself, an opportunity to evaluate the profiles. As a further example, in certain embodiments, fourth series of profile recommendations 320c may include new profiles 130, not present in first series of profile recommendations 310. Fourth series of profile recommendations 320c may additionally include a reordering of profiles 130, previously presented in first series of profile recommendations 310. This disclosure contemplates that recommendation algorithm 145 may place a different weight on selection 315b, received from friend 110b, as compared with selection 315c, received from friend 110c, when determining fourth series of profile recommendations 320c. For example, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine fourth series of profile recommendations 320c based at least in part on selection 315b, received from friend 110b, weight 155b, assigned to friend 110b, selection 315c, received from friend 110f, and weight 155f, assigned to friend 110f, where weights 155b and 155f may be determined as described above.

[0105] In certain embodiments, permissions 150b may indicate that dater 110a has granted first friend 110b permission to select profiles 130 to present as suggestions to dater 110a, but not to select profiles 130 as potential matches for dater 110a, while permissions 150f may indicate that dater 110a has granted second friend 110f permission to select profiles 130 as potential matches for dater 110a. In such embodiments, recommendation algorithm 145 may determine fourth series of profile recommendations 320c by taking into account both the suggestions provided by first friend 110b and the selections of potential matches provided by second friend 110f, as each described, individually, above.

[0106] Recommendation engine 165 may be a software module stored in memory 140 and executed by processor 135. An example algorithm for recommendation engine 165 is as follows: (1) receive a request 305 for profile recommendations from first dater 110a, first friend 110b of first dater 110a, and/or second friend 110f of first dater 110a; (2) transmit first series of profile recommendations 310 to the user 110 who submitted request 305; (3) receive a selection 315 of a profile 130 recommended in first series of profiles recommendations 310, from the user 110 who submitted request 305; (4) determine, using algorithm 145, based at least on the selection 315 and a weight 155 assigned to user 110, a new series of profile recommendations 320; (5) transmit the new series of profile recommendations 320 to dater 110a. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for recommendation engine 165, this disclosure contemplates that recommendation engine 165 may use any algorithm operable to generate and transmit recommendations of profiles 130 to users 110. For example, the algorithm used by recommendation engine 165 may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by recommendation engine 165 may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0107] While FIGS. 3A through 3C illustrate recommendation engine 165 generating recommendations 310 and 320 of profiles 130 for dater 110a, as well as transmitting such

recommendations to dater 110a, first friend 110b, and second friend 110f, this disclosure contemplates that recommendation engine 165 may generate recommendations 310 and 320 and transmit such recommendations to any number of users 110. Furthermore, this disclosure contemplates that modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to recommendation engine 165 without departing from the scope of the invention. For example, this disclosure contemplates that some or all of the operations described above as being performed by recommendation engine 165 may be performed by other components of matching tool 105. Such components may be integrated or separated. Furthermore, the operations may be performed using any suitable logic comprising software, hardware, and/or other logic.

[0108] FIGS. 4A through 4C present examples illustrating the process by which matching engine 170 of matching tool 105 generates matches between first dater 110a and second dater 110b. FIG. 4A illustrates an example embodiment where daters 110 match with other daters 110 by providing positive preference indications in response to viewing profiles 130 of other daters 110 with whom they would like to be matched. FIGS. 4B and 4C illustrate example embodiments where matching tool 105 may enable friends 110b and 110d of daters 110a and 110c to match on behalf of the daters 110a and 110c with whom they are friends.

[0109] FIG. 4A illustrates the process by which matching engine 170 generates a match 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110b, based on selections 415a and 420a provided by first dater 110a and second dater 110b, respectively. As illustrated in FIG. 4A, recommendation engine 165 may use recommendation algorithm 145 to generate first series of profile recommendations 405 to transmit to first dater 110a. First series of profile recommendations 405 may include profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110b. Similarly, recommendation engine 165 may use recommendation algorithm 145 to generate second series of profile recommendations 410 to transmit to second dater 110b. Second series of profile recommendations 410 may include profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a.

[0110] In response to receiving first series of profile recommendations 405, first dater 110a may select one or more profiles 130 presented in first series of profile recommendations 405, to indicate that first dater 110a is interested in matching with the daters 110 to whom profiles 130 belong. For example, first dater 110a may transmit selection 415a of profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110b, to matching engine 170 to indicate that first dater 110a is interested in matching with second dater 110b. Similarly, in response to receiving second series of profile recommendations 410, second dater 110b may select one or more profiles 130 presented in second series of profile recommendations 410, to indicate that second dater 110b is interested in matching with the daters 110 to whom profiles 130 belong. For example, second dater 110b may transmit selection 420a of profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, to matching engine 170, to indicate that second dater 110b is interested in matching with first dater 110a.

[0111] Matching engine 170 is configured to compare selections 415a and 420a, received from first dater 110a and second dater 110b, to determine whether or not to generate any matches for first dater 110a and second dater 110b. For example, matching engine 170 is configured to generate match 425a between first dater 110a and second dater 110b, by determining that first dater 110a selected profile 130c,

belonging to second dater 110c, and second dater 110c selected profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a. Once matching engine 170 has generated match 425a between first dater 110a and second dater 110c, matching engine 170 may move profile 110c, belonging to second dater 110c, from first series of profiles 405 to a list of matches for first dater 110a. Similarly, matching engine 170 may move profile 110a, belonging to first dater 110a, from second series of profiles 410 to a list of matches for second dater 110c. Chatting engine 180 may also enable communication between first dater 110a and second dater 110c, as described in further detail below, in the discussion of FIG. 6.

[0112] FIG. 4B presents an example in which friend 110b of first dater 110a is able to generate match 425b between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. As illustrated in FIG. 4B, recommendation engine 165 may transmit first series of profiles 405 to friend 110b of first dater 110a. As described above, first series of profiles 405 may include profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c. Provided that first dater 110a has granted friend 110b permission to generate matches on his/her behalf, friend 110b may select profile 130c from amongst the profiles 130 presented in first series of profiles 405. For example, friend 110b may select profile 130c in response to viewing profile 130c and determining that dater 110c, to whom profile 130c belongs, would likely make a good match with dater 110a. Friend 110b may then transmit his/her selection of profile 130c to matching engine 170, as selection 415b. Matching engine 170 may then generate match 425b between first dater 110a and second dater 110c, in response to determining that second dater 110c selected profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, in response to receiving second series of profiles 410, which included profile 130a.

[0113] FIG. 4C presents an example in which friend 110b of first dater 110a and friend 110d of second dater 110c are able to generate match 425c between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. As illustrated in FIG. 4C, recommendation engine 165 may transmit second series of profile 410 to friend 110d of second dater 110c. As described above, second series of profiles 410 may include profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a. Provided that second dater 110c has granted friend 110d permission to generate matches on his/her behalf, friend 110d may select profile 130a from amongst the profiles 130 presented in second series of profiles 410. For example, friend 110d may select profile 130a in response to viewing profile 130a and determining that dater 110a, to whom profile 130a belongs, would likely make a good match with dater 110c. Friend 110d may then transmit his/her selection of profile 130a to matching engine 170, as selection 420b. Matching engine 170 may then generate match 425c between first dater 110a and second dater 110c in response to determining that friend 110b of first dater 110a selected profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c, in response to receiving first series of profiles 405, which included profile 130c.

[0114] Matching engine 170 may be a software module stored in memory 140 and executed by processor 135. An example algorithm for matching engine 170 is as follows: (1) receive selection 415 from first dater 110a or friend 110b of first dater 110a; (2) receive selection 420 from second dater 110c or friend 110d of second dater 110c; (3) determine whether selection 415 includes profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c; (4) determine whether selection 420 includes profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a; (5) if

selection 415 includes profile 130c and selection 420 includes profile 130a, generate match 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110c and transmit match 425 to first dater 110a and second dater 110c; and (6) if selection 415 does not include profile 130c and/or selection 420 does not include profile 130a, do not generate match 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for matching engine 170, this disclosure contemplates that matching engine 170 may use any algorithm operable to generate matches between users 110. For example, the algorithm used by matching engine 170 may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by matching engine 170 may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0115] While FIGS. 4A through 4C illustrate matching engine 170 generating matches 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110c, based a comparison between input from first dater 110a and/or friend 110b of first dater 110a, and input from second dater 110c and/or friend 110d of second dater 110c, this disclosure contemplates that matching engine 170 may generate matches between any number of users 110, in any suitable manner, based on input from the users 110 and/or any number of other users. Furthermore, this disclosure contemplates that modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to matching engine 170 without departing from the scope of the invention. For example, this disclosure contemplates that some or all of the operations described above as being performed by matching engine 170 may be performed by other components of matching tool 105. Such components may be integrated or separated. Furthermore, the operations may be performed using any suitable logic comprising software, hardware, and/or other logic.

[0116] In certain embodiments, matches 425b (of FIG. 4B) and 425c (of FIG. 4C), generated by at least one of friends 110b and 110d may be indistinguishable from match 425a (of FIG. 4A) generated entirely by daters 110a and 110c, themselves. For example, when first dater 110a receives match 425c between him/herself and second dater 110c, first dater 110a may be unaware that friend 110d of dater 110b selected his/her profile, rather than dater 110b him/herself. On the other hand, in some embodiments, match 425 may include an indication of the user 110 who helped generate the match. For example, match 425c, generated according to the process illustrated in FIG. 4C, may indicate to first dater 110a that it was a friend of second dater 110c who thought that first dater 110a and second dater 110c should be matched.

[0117] In certain embodiments, daters 110a and 110c may be permitted to override selections 415b and 420b submitted to matching engine 170 by friends 110b and 110d, respectively. For example, daters 110a and 110c may be permitted to view selections 415b and 420b and to cancel any selections that they do not approve of. In some embodiments, daters 110a and 110c may not be permitted to override any selections 415b and 420b submitted to matching engine 170. In certain embodiments, daters 110a and 110c may be permitted to un-match with any of the daters that a friend has matched them with. For example, in response to viewing match 425b or 425c, generated based on selection 415b made by friend 110b, and determining that he/she does not

want to be matched with second dater **110c**, first dater **110a** may remove match **425b** or **425c** from his/her list of matches, thereby unmatching with second dater **110c**.

[0118] In certain embodiments, matching engine **170** may be configured to generate matches between groups of daters. For example, first dater **110a** may generate a first group of daters from certain members of his/her friend list and/or team/group. This first group of daters may include first dater **110a**, third dater **110g**, and fourth dater **110h**, for example. In certain embodiments, the members of the group may (1) assign a name to their group, (2) create an icon for their group, and/or (3) include any sort of distinguishing feature to identify the group. Once a group of daters has been created, the group may act collectively, as a unit, to select other groups of daters in the hopes of generating a group-based match. For example, the first group of daters may select a second group of daters that includes, for example, second dater **110c**, fifth dater **110i**, and sixth dater **110j**. If this second group of daters similarly selects the first group of daters, then matching engine **170** may generate a match between the first group of daters and the second group of daters. Such a match may enable the members of the first group of daters and the members of the second group of daters to communicate with one another in a group chat generated by chatting engine **180**. This aspect of matching tool **105** is described in further detail above, in the discussion of FIG. 1.

[0119] FIG. 5 presents an example activity feed **500**, generated by feed generator **175** and associated with a given dater **110a**. FIG. 5 illustrates activity feed **500** as displayed on device **115a** of dater **110a**. However, this disclosure contemplates that activity feed **500**, associated with dater **110a**, may also be displayed on device **115b** of friend **110b**. In certain embodiments, activity feed **500** may illustrate the actions taken by a dater **110a** as well as his/her friends **110b**, while interacting with matching tool **105**. In this manner, activity feed **500** may enable matching tool **105** to further involve a dater's friends in the online dating experience, as well as to notify the dater of the actions taken by his/her friends on his/her behalf.

[0120] In certain embodiments, and as illustrated in FIG. 5, activity feed **500** may be a "team-centric" activity feed. For example, feed generator **175** may generate and display activity feed **500** for dater **110a** as well as for each member of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or each member of dater **110a**'s friend list, where activity feed **500** illustrates the activities performed by dater **110a** as well as the activities performed by each member of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list on behalf of dater **110a**. In certain embodiments in which dater **110a** has more than one team/group and/or is a member of another dater's team/group and/or friend list, dater **110a** may receive multiple activity feeds **500**, where each activity feed is associated with a different team/group and/or friend list. Dater **110a** may then be able to switch between the multiple activity feeds **500**, generated by feed generator **175**, depending on which team/group and/or friend list he/she would like to view activity for, at a given point in time. Similarly, when a user **110b** is a member of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list and is also a member of another dater's team/group and/or friend list, user **110b** may alternatively view a separate activity feed **500** for each team/group and/or friend list to which he/she is a member. As illustrated in FIG. 5, in certain embodiments, activity feed **500** may display an indication **505** of the

team/group and/or dater **110** to which activity feed **500** is directed. For example, indication **505**, depicted in FIG. 5, indicates that activity feed **500** is directed to the activities of the members of first dater **110a**'s team/group.

[0121] In certain embodiments, any activity that user **110** performs as a member of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list may appear in the activity feed **500** associated with that team/group and/or friend list. As an example, activity feed **500** may indicate that dater **110a** selected one or more profiles **130**. For example, as illustrated in FIG. 5, activity feed **500** may display profile picture **520**, belonging to dater **110a**, along with message **525** stating that "1st dater was perusing profiles," or any similar phrase to indicate that first dater **110a** was selecting profiles **130** from amongst a series of profile recommendations generated and presented to first dater **110a** by recommendation engine **165**. Activity feed **500** may further display profile pictures **530a**, **530b**, and **530c**, from the profiles **130** selected by first dater **110a**.

[0122] As another example, activity feed **500** may indicate that friend **110f** of first dater **110a** generated a match for first dater **110a** (e.g., friend **110f** selected profile **130c**, belonging to second dater **110c**, and second dater **110c** or a member of second dater **110c**'s team/group and/or friend list also selected profile **130a** belonging to first dater **110a**). For example, as illustrated in FIG. 5, activity feed **500** may display profile picture **535**, belonging to friend **110f**, along with message **540** stating that "2nd friend found a match for 1st dater," or any similar phrase to indicate that a selection of profile **130c** by friend **110f** resulted in a match between first dater **110a** and second dater **110c**.

[0123] Further examples of the activities performed by members of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list (including activities performed by dater **110a** him/herself) which may be displayed in activity feed **500** include: (1) when dater **110a** receives a message from one of his/her matches; (2) when dater **110a** sends a message to one of his/her matches; (3) when friend **110b** messages one of dater **110a**'s matches on dater's **110a** behalf; (4) when dater **110a** sends/receives a message from a member of his/her friend list and/or team/group; (5) when friend **110b** suggests a profile **130** to dater **110a**; and/or (6) any other activities that may be performed by members of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list.

[0124] In certain embodiments, despite the fact that activity feed **500** may be a "team-centric" activity feed, the version of activity feed **500** presented to dater **110a** may be different from the version of activity feed **500** presented to friend **110b**, who is a member of dater **110a**'s team/group and/or friend list. Such differences may arise due to permissions **150** set for friend **110b**. For example, dater **110a** may not want friend **110b** to know each time dater **110a** begins a conversation with one of his matches. Accordingly, dater **110a** may set permissions **150b** for friend **110b** to indicate that the activity feed **500** presented to friend **110b** is not to display any indications when dater **110a** begins a conversation with one of his matches. As another example, in certain embodiments, the version of activity feed **500** presented to dater **110a** may be different from the version of activity feed **500** present to friend **110b** of dater **110a** as a result of permissions **150** set by other friends of dater **110a**. For example, friend **110f** of dater **110a** may set permissions **150** such that only dater **110a** may view the activities performed by friend **110f** on behalf of dater **110a** in activity feed **500**. As described above, in addition to governing the

information that may be presented on activity feed 500, permissions 150 may also specify the actions that friends 110 may take on behalf of dater 110a when interacting with matching tool 105.

[0125] Feed generator 175 may be a software module stored in memory 140 and executed by processor 135. An example algorithm for feed generator 175, used to generate a “team-centric” activity feed 500 is as follows: (1) for each member of dater 110a’s team/group and/or friend list, determine that the member performed an activity on behalf of dater 110a, and add a description of the activity to activity feed 500; (2) generate a version of activity feed 500 for each member of dater 110a’s team/group and/or friend list, by removing those activities from activity feed 500 that permissions 150 belonging to the member indicate that the member is not permitted to view; and (3) transmit each version of activity feed 500 to the associated member of dater 110a’s team/group and/or friend list. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for feed generator 175, this disclosure contemplates that feed generator 175 may use any algorithm operable to generate feed 500, illustrating the activities of users 110. For example, the algorithm used by feed generator 175 may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by feed generator 175 may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0126] In certain embodiments, rather than generating a “team-centric” activity feed, feed generator 175 may generate a “user-centric” activity feed. For example, rather than generating multiple activity feeds 500 for each team/group and/or friend list belonging to user 110 and/or each team/group and/or friend list to which user 110 belongs, feed generator 175 may generate a single activity feed 500 for user 110. This single activity feed may include activities performed by user 110 as well as activities affecting user 110 and performed by any of the other users to which user 110 is connected by matching tool 105. In certain embodiments, user-centric activity feed 500 may additionally include friend-of-a-friend activities. For example, consider a situation in which both user 110b and user 110f are friends of dater 110a, but are not connected with one another through matching tool 105 (e.g., user 110b is not a member of user 110f’s team/group and/or friend list and user 110f is not a member of user 110b’s team/group and/or friend list). Activity feed 500 generated by feed generator 175 for user 110b may nevertheless include activities performed by user 110f on behalf of dater 110a, given dater 110a’s connection with user 110b. Similarly, activity feed 500 generated by feed generator 175 for user 110f may include activities performed by user 110b on behalf of dater 110a, given dater 110a’s connection with user 110f. In such embodiments, users 110b and 110f may be able to control whether the activities they perform on behalf of dater 110a appear in one another’s activity feeds 500, through permissions 150. For example, user 110b may be able to set permissions 150 for friends-of-friends through a privacy setting offered by matching tool 105.

[0127] An example algorithm for feed generator 175, used to generate a “user-centric” activity feed 500 for user 110 is as follows: (1) determine that user 110 performed an activity using matching tool 105 and add a description of the activity

to activity feed 500; (2) determine that a member of user 110’s team/group and/or friend list performed an activity on behalf of user 110 and add a description of the activity to activity feed 500; (3) determine that a member of a given dater’s team/group and/or friend list, to which user 110 is also a member, performed an activity on behalf of the dater; (4) determine whether the member of the team/group and/or friend list has set a privacy setting offered by matching tool 105 to allow friend-of-a-friend activity sharing; (5) if the member of the team/group and/or friend list has set the privacy setting to allow friend-of-a-friend activity sharing, add a description of the activity performed by the member of the team/group and/or friend list on behalf of the dater to activity feed 500; and (6) transmit activity feed 500 to user 110. While the above example presents one possible algorithm for feed generator 175, this disclosure contemplates that feed generator 175 may use any algorithm operable to generate feed 500, illustrating the activities of users 110. For example, the algorithm used by feed generator 175 may include modifications, additions, or omissions to the example algorithm presented above. Furthermore, the algorithm used by feed generator 175 may include more, fewer, or other steps as compared with the example algorithm presented above, and the steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order.

[0128] FIG. 6 illustrates an example graphical user interface 600 associated with a group chat amongst friends of dater 110a, and displayed on device 115b, belonging to friend 110b. Graphical user interface 600 may be generated by chatting engine 180 (of FIG. 1), and may enable friends of dater 110a to share profiles 130 with both dater 110a and other friends of dater 110a and/or members of dater 110a’s team/group, as illustrated in FIG. 6. For example, each profile 130 may include an interactive button through which a user 110 may select the profile to share in a group chat. In response to user 110 selecting profile 130 to share in a group chat, graphical user interface 600 may display profile picture 605, associated with profile 130, along with text box 615. User 110 may use text box 615 to input comments about profile 130 that he/she wishes to share with the other participants in the group chat. Once user 110 has finished inputting comments into text box 615, user 110 may then share both these comments and profile 130 with the other participants of the group chat by selecting button 610.

[0129] In certain embodiments, in response to user 110 sharing profile 130 with the other participants of the group chat, one or more members of the group chat may be able to select profile 130 directly from the group chat. For example, dater 110a may select profile 130 directly from the group chat, indicating that dater 110a would like to be matched with the dater to whom profile 130 belongs. As another example, friend 110b may select profile 130 directly from the group chat, generating either a potential match for dater 110a or a suggestion for dater 110a, depending on permissions 150b provided to friend 110b by dater 110a.

[0130] In certain embodiments, in addition to enabling friends of dater 110a to share profiles 130 with one another, chatting engine 180 may be able to enable friends of dater 110a to share activities displayed in activity feed 500 with one another. As a specific example, in response to viewing on activity feed 500 that first friend 110b suggested profile 130c to dater 110a, second friend 110f may share this event in the group chat for dater 110a’s team/group and/or friend list and comment that he/she approves of this suggestion.

[0131] In addition to enabling users 110 to share profiles 130 with one another in group chats, chatting engine 180 may facilitate any suitable form of communication between users 110, as described in further detail above, in the discussion of FIG. 1.

[0132] FIG. 7 presents a flowchart illustrating the method by which matching tool 105 may generate matches 425 between a pair of daters 110a and 110c.

[0133] In step 705 matching tool 105 (of FIG. 1) generates and transmits first series of profile recommendations 405. First series of profile recommendations 405 may include profiles 130 belonging to daters 110 that matching tool 105 has determined are likely compatible with first dater 110a. This disclosure contemplates that matching tool 105 may transmit first series of profile recommendations 405 to first dater 110a and/or a friend 110b of first dater 110a. In step 710 matching tool 105 receives a selection 415 of profile 130c, belonging to second dater 110c. In step 715 matching tool 105 determines whether selection 415 was received from first dater 110a or friend 110b of first dater 110a.

[0134] If, in step 715 matching tool 105 determines that selection 415 was received from first dater 110a, then in step 735 matching tool 105 determines whether the tool has received a selection 420 of profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, from second dater 110c. If, in step 735 matching tool 105 determines that the tool has received a selection 420 of profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, from second dater 110c, in step 745 matching tool 105 generates match 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. In step 750 matching tool 105 enables communication between first dater 110a and second dater 110c.

[0135] If, in step 735 matching tool 105 determine that the tool has not received a selection 420 of profile 130a, belonging to first dater 110a, from second dater 110c, in step 740 matching tool 105 determines whether the tool has received a selection 420 of profile 130a from friend 110d of second dater 110c. If, in step 740 matching tool 105 determines that the tool has received a selection 420 of profile 130a from friend 110d of second dater 110c, in step 745 matching tool 105 generates match 425 between first dater 110a and second dater 110c and in step 750 matching tool 105 enables communication between first dater 110a and second dater 110c. On the other hand, if, in step 740 matching tool 105 determines that the tool has not received a selection 420 of profile 130a from friend 110d of second dater 110c, matching tool 105 does not generate a match between first dater 110a and second dater 110c.

[0136] If, in step 715 matching tool 105 determines that selection 415 was received from friend 110b of first dater 110a, then in step 720, matching tool 105 determines whether friend 110b has been granted permission by first dater 110a to select potential matches for first dater 110a. If, in step 720 matching tool 105 determines that friend 110b has been granted permission by first dater 110a to select potential matches for first dater 110a, the method proceeds to step 735, and continues from step 735 as described above.

[0137] If, in step 720 matching tool 105 determines that friend 110b has not been granted permission by first dater 110a to select potential matches for first dater 110a, then, in step 725 matching tool 105 treats selection 415 from friend 110b as a suggestion for dater 110a. Accordingly, matching tool 105 reorders the profiles 130 in first series of profile recommendations 405 into a second series of profile recommendations, in which profile 130c, belonging to dater 110c,

is placed earlier in the series than in first series of profile recommendations 405. For example, matching tool 105 may reorder the profiles 130 in first series of profile recommendations 405 into the second series of profile recommendations by placing profile 130c at the beginning of the second series of profile recommendations. Additionally, matching tool 105 may place an indication on profile 130c that friend 110b has suggested profile 130c for first dater 110a. In step 730 matching tool 105 transmits the second series of profile recommendations to first dater 110a for selection therefrom.

[0138] Modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to method 700 depicted in FIG. 7. Method 700 may include more, fewer, or other steps. For example, steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order. While discussed as matching tool 105 (or components thereof) performing the steps, any suitable component of system 100, such as device(s) 115 for example, may perform one or more steps of the method.

[0139] FIG. 8 presents a flowchart illustrating the method by which matching tool 105 may generate recommendations of potentially compatible users 110 for a dater 110a.

[0140] In step 805 matching tool 105 transmits a first series of profile recommendations 310 to dater 110a, first friend 110b of dater 110a, and/or second friend 110f of dater 110a. In step 810 matching tool 105 receives a selection 315 of one or more profiles 130 presented in first series of profile recommendations 310. In step 815 matching tool 105 determines if selection 315 was received from dater 110a.

[0141] If, in step 815 matching tool 105 determines that selection 315 was received from dater 110a, in step 825 matching tool 105 determines weight 155a assigned to dater 110a. On the other hand, if, in step 815 matching tool 105 determines that selection 315 was received from first friend 110b or second friend 110f, in step 820 matching tool 105 determines weight 155b, assigned to first friend 110b, or weight 155f, assigned to second friend 110f. In step 830 matching tool 105 determines a second series of profile recommendations 320 for dater 110a, based at least in part on selection 315 and weight 155a, using matching algorithm 145. In step 835 matching tool 105 determines whether or not a request has been received from any of dater 110a, first friend 110b, and second friend 110f for additional profile recommendations. If, in step 835 matching tool 105 determines that a request has been received for additional profile recommendations, in step 840 matching tool 105 transmits second series of profile recommendations 320. Method 800 then proceeds to step 810 and continues from step 810 as described above.

[0142] Modifications, additions, or omissions may be made to method 800 depicted in FIG. 8. Method 800 may include more, fewer, or other steps. For example, steps may be performed in parallel or in any suitable order. While discussed as matching tool 105 (or components thereof) performing the steps, any suitable component of system 100, such as device(s) 115 for example, may perform one or more steps of the method.

[0143] Although the present disclosure includes several embodiments, a myriad of changes, variations, alterations, transformations, and modifications may be suggested to one skilled in the art, and it is intended that the present disclosure encompass such changes, variations, alterations, transformations, and modifications as falling within the scope of the appended claims.

- 1.-20. (canceled)
21. An apparatus comprising:
 an interface configured to send and receive data over a network; and
 a hardware processor operably coupled with the interface, and configured to:
 create a first group comprising a first user profile associated with a first user and a second user profile associated with a second user;
 create a second group comprising a third user profile associated with a third user;
 determine that the first user from the first group is compatible with the third user from the second group based at least on a similarity between the first user profile and the third user profile; and
 in response to determining that the first user from the first group is compatible with the third user from the second group:
 transmit, using the interface, an indication of the first group to a first user device associated with the third user;
 receive, using the interface, a selection of the first group by the third user from the first user device; and
 in response to receiving the selection of the first group by the third user from the first user device:
 generate a group match between the first group and the second group; and
 enable communication between the first group and the second group in a group chat.
22. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein creating the first group is in response to:
 receiving a selection of an icon on the second user profile associated with the second user from a second user device associated with the first user.
23. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein creating the first group is in response to:
 receiving a request to create the first group from a second user device associated with the first user.
24. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein in response to the first group being created, the first group acts as a unit.
25. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein the indication of the first group comprises an icon for the first group.
26. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein the first user is assigned a permission by the second user to act on behalf of the first group.
27. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein enabling communication between the first group and the second group in the group chat is further in response:
 transmitting, using the interface, an indication of the second group to a second user device associated with the first user; and
 receiving, using the interface, a selection of the second group by the first user from the second user device.
28. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein the hardware processor is further configured to:
 generate a graphical user interface that displays the first group, wherein within the graphical user interface, the first user profile is represented by a first graphical element, the second user profile is represented by a second graphical element, and the indication is represented by a third graphical element.
29. The Apparatus of claim 21, wherein the hardware processor is further configured to:
 generate a graphical user interface that displays the group chat in an activity feed, wherein the activity feed displays a set of actions performed by each member of the first group and each member of the second group, and user profiles associated members of the first group and the second group.
30. The Apparatus of claim 29, wherein the graphical user interface representing the activity feed is updated as new incoming messages are exchanged between any member of the first group and the third user from the second group.
31. A method comprising:
 creating, by a processor, a first group comprising a first user profile associated with a first user and a second user profile associated with a second user;
 creating, by the processor, a second group comprising a third user profile associated with a third user;
 determining, by the processor, that the first user from the first group is compatible with the third user from the second group based at least on a similarity between the first user profile and the third user profile; and
 in response to determining that the first user from the first group is compatible with the third user from the second group:
 transmitting, using an interface, an indication of the first group to a first user device associated with the third user;
 receiving, using the interface, a selection of the first group by the third user from the first user device; and
 in response to receiving the selection of the first group by the third user from the first user device:
 generating, by the processor, a group match between the first group and the second group; and
 enabling, by the processor, communication between the first group and the second group in a group chat.
32. The method of claim 31, wherein creating the first group is in response to:
 receiving, using the interface, a selection of an icon on the second user profile associated with the second user from a second user device associated with the first user.
33. The method of claim 31, wherein creating the first group is in response to:
 receiving, using the interface, a request to create the first group from a second user device associated with the first user.
34. The method of claim 31, wherein in response to the first group being created, the first group acts as a unit.
35. The method of claim 31, wherein the indication of the first group comprises an icon for the first group.
36. The method of claim 31, wherein the first user is assigned a permission by the second user to act on behalf of the first group.
37. The method of claim 31, wherein enabling communication between the first group and the second group in the group chat is further in response:
 transmitting, using the interface, an indication of the second group to a second user device associated with the first user; and
 receiving, using the interface, a selection of the second group by the first user from the second user device.
38. The method of claim 31, further comprising:
 generating, by the processor, a graphical user interface that displays the first group, wherein within the graphical user interface, the first user profile is represented by

a first graphical element, the second user profile is represented by a second graphical element, and the indication is represented by a third graphical element.

39. The method of claim **31**, further comprising:

generating, by the processor, a graphical user interface that displays the group chat in an activity feed, wherein the activity feed displays a set of actions performed by each member of the first group and each member of the second group, and user profiles associated members of the first group and the second group.

40. The method of claim **39**, wherein the graphical user interface representing the activity feed is updated as new incoming messages are exchanged between any member of the first group and the third user from the second group.

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